

BY ODHIAMBO DARREN GREGORY.

+254704597085.



KENYATTA UNIVERSITY
INSTITUTE OF OPEN & VIRTUAL LEARNING
LITERATURE DEPARTMENT
ALT 210: EAST AFRICAN PROSE FICTION

WRITTEN BY:

ESTHER K. MBITHI

EDITED BY:

GEORGE NYANDORO

Copyright © Kenyatta University, 2011

All Rights Reserved Published By:

KENYATTA UNIVERSITY PRESS



INTRODUCTION

Hello and welcome to ALT200. This is a second year literature course. For this course, we shall read and analyse selected novels and short stories from East Africa. Prose fiction in East Africa is rich and vibrant. It is a twentieth century phenomenon, and yet it includes works of art in English, Kiswahili, French, and African languages.

We shall start with a general overview of the countries that make up the East African Community. After that we shall kick off the course with a discussion of early prose fiction. Early prose fiction includes works by immigrants from Europe (which are dealt with more comprehensively in ALT 205 Expatriate Literature on Africa), anti-colonial literature, and national literature.

Most of you know a bit of East African history. You know, therefore, that East Africa has been through great historical upheavals in the relatively short span of fifty years. As a result the literature reflects a multiplicity of themes and concerns that in other parts of the world took hundreds of years to become manifest. Post independence literature in East Africa therefore includes not only post colonial literature but a host of other universal themes discernible in literature from other parts of the world. You will engage with these themes as we go through the course.



OBJECTIVES

By the end of this course, you should be able to:

- Know which countries in East Africa are covered in this course and understand the historical background of each.
- Understand the influence of European literature on East African prose fiction.
- Situate the thematic concerns of writers from East Africa within the geographical, historical, cultural, social, political and economic circumstances in which they have taken shape.
- Discuss the development of prose writing in East Africa with reference to specific novels and short stories.

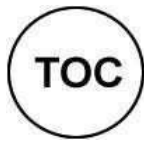


TABLE OF CONTENTS

LECTURE	LECTURE TITLE	PAGE
	Primary Texts	4
1	Lecture One: Scope and Limitations	5
2	Lecture Two: The 'Other's' Point of View	15
3	Lecture Three: East African Pioneer Prose Writers	22
4	Lecture Four: Style and Narrative Techniques	29
5	Lecture Five: Theoretical Concerns	35
6	Lecture Six: Urbanisation, Poverty and Crime	47

7	Lecture Seven: Relationships	55
8	Lecture Eight: Materialism and Immorality	65
9	Lecture Nine: Violence	75
10	Lecture Ten: Differences and Hostilities	82
11	Lecture Eleven: Genocide	89
12	Lecture Twelve: HIV/Aids	99
13	Conclusion: Into the 21 st Century	105
	Glossary	111
	Answers to Self Test Questions	112
	References	120

PRIMARY TEXTS

Blixen, Karen (Isak Dinesen). Out of Africa. Glasgow: The University Press, 1937. Reprinted by Penguin Books, 1954.

Kenya Institute of Education, ed. The Winner and other Stories. Nairobi: Kenya Literature Bureau, 1994 (reprinted 1997).

Kibera, Valerie, ed. An Anthology of East African Short Stories. Nairobi. Longman Group Ltd. 1988.

Okurut, Mary Karooro. The Invisible Weevil. Kampala: FEMRITE Publications Ltd., 1998

Ogot, Grace. Land Without Thunder. Nairobi: East African Educational Publishers, 1968. Eighth impression printed in 2001.

Rusimbi, John. The Hyena's Wedding. London: Janus Publishing Company, 2007.

Zettersten, Arne, ed. East African Literature, An Anthology. London and New York: Longman, 1983.

LECTURE ONE SCOPE AND LIMITATIONS



1.1 INTRODUCTION

This is the first lecture in the course East African Prose Fiction. In this lecture you will learn about the countries that make up the East African Community. I will also talk about the languages spoken in these countries. Towards the end, I will give you a listing of some of East Africa's pioneer prose fiction writers and some of the prose fiction titles published in the 1960s.

Until recently, when we talked about East Africa we were referring to the three countries of Kenya, Tanzania and Uganda. In 2010, Burundi and Rwanda joined the East African Community. In this lecture I will talk briefly about the historical developments that have led to the reality of an East African Community.



1.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Name the countries that make up the East African community.
- Trace the historical development of each and pick out the differences and/or similarities between countries.
- Identify some pioneer prose writers from East Africa.



1.3 THE COUNTRIES OF EAST AFRICA

The East African Community is made up of five countries:

1. Burundi
2. Kenya
3. Rwanda
4. Tanzania
5. Uganda

Although these five countries have a lot in common, each has followed a unique historical path to the twenty-first century. I will therefore talk briefly about each country before we start our discussion of East African prose fiction in the next lecture.

1.3.1 BURUNDI

The political entity known as the Republic of Burundi today covers 27,816 square kilometres, and is home to 8.3 million people. In pre-colonial days, the people of Burundi lived as one ethnic group under the rule of a king. They spoke one language, Kirundi. Following the partition of Africa by Europe, Burundi became part of German East Africa until 1918. In 1922 it fell, jointly with Rwanda, under the administration of Belgium. At independence in 1962, a constitutional monarchy was established. The royal family was overthrown in 1966, and the country has suffered a turbulent political climate since then. The word genocide has almost become synonymous with the name Burundi, and many Burundians have died in ethnic violence.

Burundi is finally beginning to benefit from an internationally brokered peace process, but the economy remains predominantly agrarian, with much of its foreign exchange earnings coming from coffee and tea. Burundi has a strong oral tradition. History and life lessons are relayed through storytelling, poetry, and song. This is evident in *kivivuga amazina*, an improvisational poetry contest played by cattle herders, in which they boast their abilities or accomplishments.

Tragically, many Burundians involved in higher education died in the 1972 genocide. This has had a devastating impact on written culture in Burundi. Literacy levels are low. Radio is the main source of information for many Burundians. There are broadcasts in Kirundi, Kiswahili, French and English. All of them are state-controlled since the government runs the sole TV

station, the only radio station that transmits beyond the capital city, and the only newspaper that publishes regularly.

1.3.2 KENYA

Lying squarely astride the equator, the Republic of Kenya covers an area of 582,646 square kilometres and is home to 40 million people. The country is known as 'the cradle of mankind' because some of the earliest evidence of man's existence has been found within its borders. There are more than forty ethnic groups in Kenya, each with its own language. However, Kiswahili and English are spoken by all. Kenya was a colony of Britain between 1880 and 1963 when it attained political independence. It has been relatively stable politically since then, and has consequently enjoyed some modest development. The country's eastern borders lie on the Indian Ocean, and the port of Mombasa has been an important gateway to East Africa since the fifteenth century.

Most Kenyans rely on broadcast media, particularly the radio, for news. The media is diverse and liberalised, with some private networks having near-national coverage. Kenya has a large middle class, a vibrant economy and an established publishing industry. The Kenyan education system is organised and reputable. Literacy levels are relatively high.

With its scenic beauty and abundant wildlife, Kenya is one of Africa's major safari destinations.

1.3.3 RWANDA

The Republic of Rwanda covers 26,338 square kilometres and is home to 10 million people. Like Burundi, Rwanda was part of German East Africa, falling under Belgian administration in 1922. Long before the departure of the Belgians in 1962, the country was beset by ethnic tension associated with the traditionally unequal relationship between the dominant Tutsi minority and the majority Hutus.

In the course of a few months in 1994, Rwanda went through a state-sponsored genocide. More than one million people died. The killing rate was five times that achieved by the Nazis.

Tensions continue to simmer, but the herculean task of rebuilding the country has started and seems to be paying off. Abundant wildlife, including rare mountain gorillas have led to a fast-growing tourism sector. The largest cities in Rwanda are Kigali, Gitarana and Butare. Unlike many African countries, Rwanda is home to only one significant ethnic and linguistic group, the Banyarwanda. The country is well known for its native styles of dance, particularly the Intore dance, and for its drummers. Kinyarwanda, English and French are the official languages. Kiswahili is widely spoken.

1.3.4 TANZANIA

The United Republic of Tanzania covers an area of 945,203 square kilometres and is home to 43 million people. The country's eastern borders lie on the Indian Ocean and, the major coastal city of Dar es Salaam served as the country's political capital up to 1996. Today, the capital city is Dodoma but Dar es Salaam remains the principal commercial city of Tanzania and the de-facto seat of most government institutions.

Tanzania is a union of two states: mainland Tanganyika and Zanzibar Island. The mainland was controlled by the Germans up to the end of the First World War. Thereafter it became a British mandate, becoming independent in 1961. Zanzibar Island was under the control of the Sultan of Oman. The Arab dynasty was overthrown in 1963. Tanganyika and Zanzibar united in 1964 to form Tanzania. Tanzania is the largest country in East Africa, is home to Africa's highest peak and boasts the world's largest caldera, the Ngorongoro crater. It has been relatively peaceful over the years, but the Ujamaa policy slowed down its economic growth.

English and Kiswahili are the official languages. Kiswahili is the language of the social and political sphere. It is used as the language of instruction in primary and adult education. English is the language of instruction in secondary education and universities. It is also the language of technology and higher courts. Tanzania has many television and radio stations, numerous newspapers and many writers.

1.3.5 UGANDA

The Republic of Uganda covers an area of 236,000 square kilometres and is home to 32 million people. The southern part of the country includes a substantial portion of Lake Victoria, which is shared by Kenya and Tanzania. Uganda is home to many different ethnic groups, none of whom forms a majority of the population. It gained independence from Britain in 1962. The traditional kingdoms were abolished in 1967 in favour of a republic. Parallel with the state administration, six traditional Bantu kingdoms have remained and continue to enjoy some degrees of mainly cultural autonomy. The kingdoms are Toro, Ankole, Busoga, Bunyoro, Buganda and Rwenzururu.

For decades, Uganda's economy suffered from devastating economic policies and instability, leaving Uganda as one of the world's poorest countries. The country has commenced economic reforms and growth has been robust except for northern Uganda where a conflict which has killed thousands and displaced millions continues.

English became the official language of Uganda after independence. Kiswahili was approved as the country's second official national language in 2005. Uganda has both private and public

BY ODHIAMBO DARREN GREGORY.

+254704597085.

universities, the largest of which is Makerere University, located outside of Kampala. Illiteracy is common in Uganda.

THE FIVE EAST AFRICAN NATIONS



1.3.6 THE EAST AFRICAN COMMUNITY

The East African Community (EAC) is an intergovernmental organisation comprising the five east African countries of Burundi, Kenya, Rwanda, Tanzania and Uganda. These five countries together cover an area of 1.8 million square kilometres and have a combined population of about 133 million (July 2009 est.). The region has significant natural resources. Kenya and Tanzania have had a relatively peaceful history since achieving independence. In contrast, Burundi, Rwanda and Uganda have suffered from wars and civil strife. The most widely spoken languages of East Africa are Kiswahili, English, Kirundi and Kinyarwanda, although French is also common in Burundi and Rwanda.

Kenya, Tanzania and Uganda have had a history of co-operation dating back to the early 20th century, including the customs union between Kenya and Uganda in 1917, which the then Tanganyika joined in 1927, the East African High Commission (1948–1961), the East African Common Services Organisation (1961–1967) and the East African Community (1967–1977).

In 1977, the East African Community collapsed after ten years. Causes for the collapse included demands by Kenya for more seats than Uganda and Tanzania in decision-making organs, disagreements with Ugandan dictator Idi Amin, and the disparate economic systems of socialism in Tanzania and capitalism in Kenya. The three member states lost more than sixty years of co-operation and the benefits of economies of scale. Each of the former member states had to embark, at great expense and at lower efficiency, upon the establishment of services and industries that had previously been provided at the Community level.

On 30 November 1993, Presidents Moi of Kenya, Mwinyi of Tanzania, and Museveni of Uganda signed the Treaty for East African Co-operation in Arusha, Tanzania, establishing a Tri-partite Commission for Co-operation. A process of re-integration was embarked on involving tripartite programmes of co-operation in political, economic, social and cultural fields, research and technology, defence, security, legal and judicial affairs.

The East African Community was finally revived on November 30, 1999, when the Treaty for its re-establishment was signed. It came into force on July 7, 2000, twenty-three years after the total collapse of the defunct erstwhile Community and its organs. A customs union was signed in March 2004 which commenced on January 1, 2005.



1.4 LANGUAGES

Many languages are spoken in East Africa. In Kenya and Uganda, for example, more than forty different languages are spoken in each country. Languages, like dynasties and kingdoms, rise and wane. When a group of people are well organised and focussed, they tend to overpower and conquer their neighbours. With time they impose their culture, language, and value systems on the conquered populations. In the case of East Africa, the conquering powers were Belgium and Britain. The result is that English and French are official languages in East Africa.



1.4.1 The Languages of East Africa

The key languages of East Africa are:

1.1 **Burundi: Kirundi (official), French (official), Kiswahili** **SUBTOPIC 2**

Kenya: Kiswahili (official), English (official), Kikuyu, Dholuo, Ekegusii, Kikamba...

Rwanda: Kinyarwanda (official), French (official), English (official), Kiswahili

Tanzania: English (official), Kiswahili (official)

Uganda: English (official), Kiswahili (official), Luganda



1.5 SUMMARY

We have now come to the end of our first lecture. In this lecture, I have talked briefly about each of the countries that make up the East African Community. The rest of this course deals with prose fiction: novels and short stories. This is a second year unit offered only to students who have successfully completed ALT 101: INTRODUCTION TO LITERARY GENRES, which provides a comprehensive introduction to what Prose Fiction is. Other genres of literature are studied in two separate courses:

ALT 102: East African Oral Literature

ALT 201: East African Poetry and Drama



1.6 ACTIVITIES

I would like to ask you to carry out the following activities in preparation for future lectures:

Find out what is available on the Internet about each of the five countries whose literature is under study.

Watch the following movies. Make sure you watch each movie more than once:

- 'Something of value'
- 'Out of Africa'
- 'Ninety Minutes at Entebbe'

- 'Hotel Rwanda'

F



Movie watched, make notes about location, themes, political and social organisation.

1.7 FURTHER READING

Below are the names of some pioneer literary figures from East Africa, and some of their prose titles. Read at least one which is not on the primary reading list.

	Author	Country	Prose Titles
1	Ngugi wa Thiong'o	Kenya	Weep Not, Child The River Between A Grain of Wheat Petals of Blood
2	Grace Ogot	Kenya	The Promised Land Land Without Thunder
3	Leonard Kibera and Samuel Kahiga	Kenya	Potent Ash

4	Taban Lo Liyong	Uganda*	Fixions and other Stories
5	Eneriko Seruma	Uganda	The Experience
6	Robert Serumaga	Uganda	Return to the Shadows
7	Barbara Kimenye	Uganda	Kalasanda
8	Aniceti Kitereza	Tanzania	Myombekere na Bugonoka na Ntulanalwo na Bulihwali
9	Peter Palangyo	Tanzania	Dying in the Sun
	Shaaban Roberts	Tanzania	Maisha Yangu Kusadikika
10	Saverio Naigiziki	Rwanda	Escapade ruandaise
11	Esther Kamatari and M. Renault	Burundi	Princess des Rugo, mon histoire

*Taban Lo Liyong lived, studied and worked in East Africa as a citizen of Uganda, becoming a key player on the East African literary scene, before he became a citizen of the Sudan.



1.8 SELF TEST QUESTIONS

1. Which countries are members of the East African Community?
2. For each of the countries you have named for question 1 above, indicate when it attained its present form.
3. Name an East African Country where at least four languages are widely spoken and name the languages.

LECTURE TWO

THE 'OTHER'S' POINT OF VIEW



2.1 INTRODUCTION

In the previous lecture, I talked about the five states that are currently members of the East African Community. We saw that the three member states of Kenya, Uganda and Tanzania have had links since before their independence, and that the last two, Burundi and Rwanda, have only joined the Union after 2005. In this second lecture we will discuss prose writing about East Africa produced during the colonial period – the period before the majority of indigenous people from East Africa knew how to read and write. Consequently, we shall be looking at works of art written by European immigrants who interacted with East Africa during that time when the states that make up the East African Community today were under colonial domination.



2.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Know the place of European immigrants in the history of East Africa.
- Understand the relationship between European immigrants and the indigenous East Africans.
- Discuss the themes which are common in this kind of literature.



2.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

Literature written in East Africa in English or French is a phenomenon of the latter part of the twentieth century. However, some literature did exist in colonial times. Most of it was directed at a European audience.

Europeans who came to Africa, much like Europeans who travelled to America and Australia, tried to turn their new home into another Europe. They selected for settlement, in their new countries, those areas which most closely resembled, in vegetation cover and climate, the homes they had left behind in Europe. They built, when they could, homes like the ones they had lived in. They brought their animals and tried to cultivate the crops they had been used to cultivating. Surprisingly, many of the crops did better in East Africa than they had done in Europe. Furthermore, they found other crops and plants, exotic to them, which would not have grown in Europe.

Before the countries of East Africa attained political independence, most of the European immigrants were settler farmers: growing crops on a commercial scale for the European market.

Since literature is a mirror of life, most literary accounts from East Africa in the early part of the twentieth century are accounts of settler farmers battling the landscape and the elements in the fight for survival. They ploughed the fields, and prayed for a bumper harvest. They contracted and died of tropical illnesses. They learnt how to deal with and exploit exotic plant and animal species.



2.4 OUT OF AFRICA

One such account, and perhaps the most well known, is Karen Blixen's Out of Africa, whose opening lines are "I had a farm in Africa, at the foot of the Ngong Hills." Given the date and the prevailing circumstances, no doubt Karen Blixen had an exciting life. She was born into a well-

to-do Danish family. In 1895, Karen's father, Wilhelm Dinesen, committed suicide when he was diagnosed with syphilis. In 1913, Karen got married to a second cousin, the Swedish Baron Bror von Blixen-Finecke after a love affair between her and his brother. Karen and her husband, Baron von Blixen-Finecke, moved to Kenya and used family money to set up a coffee plantation. Their home in Kenya is the house which today is known as the Karen Blixen Museum.

Karen's husband was unfaithful to her. A year into marriage she was diagnosed with syphilis. They separated in 1921, and divorced in 1925. She then became involved with the big game hunter Denys Finch Hutton. Denys died in a plane crash in the Chyulu hills in 1931, and was buried on land that was Karen's property at the time.

Although some of these details are captured in the book Out of Africa, it is more about the mundane details of running (or trying to run) a farm. Blixen writes from the perspective that settlers are superior to the indigenous populations. She castigates them openly and ridicules their customs and beliefs. She condescendingly recounts numerous incidents which, were it not for her presence and timely intervention, would have been fatal for the indigenous Kenyans.



NOTABLE THEMES

Karen's most famous book Out of Africa was published after she returned to Denmark for good. It is therefore a nostalgic account of treasured memories. Nevertheless, it is replete with negative references to Africans. The discerning reader can make out that it was the Africans who supplied both domestic and farm labour. From the words used in the text, however, it is easy to see that the immigrant European writers did not hold the indigenous Africans in high esteem.

- Indeed, the pre-dominant theme in writing by the European immigrants is that the African is ignorant, backward and barbaric. The immigrant supposes himself or herself to be superior to the indigenous African. Other themes include:
- Turning unfamiliar territory into habitable homes and thriving farms.
- Accepting the reality of wild animals in such abundance and in close proximity.
- The role of the settler farmer in the expansion of empire.



2.5 SUMMARY

In this second lecture I have talked about colonial literature. We have discussed audience, themes and presentation in literary works produced in East Africa before the states of East Africa became politically independent. We have noted that literature produced by European immigrants living in East Africa in colonial times is more an extension of the literature of their European empires than East African literature. Nevertheless, it is an important dimension of the cultural history of East Africa because the setting is East Africa and some of the characters are indigenous Africans. In reading these works, we get an insight into the culture of East Africa at that time. We are also better placed to understand the literature produced later by indigenous East Africans.



2.6 ACTIVITY

Read the following extracts, one from Karen Blixen's Out of Africa and the other from Mazrui's World Culture and the Black Experience. Draw a comparison between the two extracts along the lines of:

- choice of words
- themes
- intended audience
- tone and style

(a). From Blixen's Out of Africa

Of Natives and History

The people who expect the Natives to jump joyfully from the stone age to the age of motor cars, forget the toil and labour which our own fathers have had, to bring us all through history up to where we are.

We can make motor cars and aeroplanes, and teach the Natives to use them. But the true love of motor cars cannot be made, in human hearts, in the turn of a hand. It takes centuries to produce it, and it is likely that Socrates, the Crusades, and the French Revolution; have been needed in the making. We of the present day, who love our machines, cannot quite imagine how people in the old days could live without them. But we could not make the Anathasian Creed, or the technique of the Mass, or of a five-act tragedy, and perhaps not

even of a sonnet. And if we had not found them there ready for our use, we should have had to do without them. Still we must imagine, since they have been made at all, that there was a time when the hearts of humanity cried out for these things, and when a deeply felt want was relieved when they were made.

Father Bernard came over on his motor bicycle one day, his bearded face all beaming with bliss and triumph, to lunch with me, and to bring me tidings of great joy. The day before, he told me, nine young Kikuyu, from the Church of Scotland Mission, had come and asked to be received into the Roman Catholic Church, because they had, upon meditation and discussion, come to hold with the doctrine of Transubstantiation of that Church.

All the people whom I told of this happening laughed at Father Bernard, and explained that the young Kikuyu had seen a chance of higher wages, of lighter work, or of getting a bicycle to ride on, at the French Mission, and had therefore invented their conversion in regard to Transubstantiation. For we ourselves, they said, cannot understand it, and we do not even like to think about it, so that to the Kikuyu it must be altogether inadmissible. But it is not quite sure that it is so; Father Bernard knew the Kikuyus well. The minds of the young Kikuyu may now be walking on the shadowy paths of our own ancestors, whom we should not disown in their eyes, who held their ideas about Transubstantiation very dear. Those people of five hundred years ago, were in their day offered higher wages, and promotion, and easier terms of life, even sometimes their very lives, and to everything they preferred their conviction about Transubstantiation. They were not offered a bicycle, but Father Bernard himself, who had got a motor bicycle, attached less value to it than to the conversion of the nine Kikuyus.

The modern white people in Africa believe in evolution and not in any sudden creative act. They might then run the Natives through a short practical lesson of history to bring them up to where we are. We took these nations over not quite forty years ago; if we compare that moment to the moment of the birth of the Lord, and allow them to catch up with us, three years to our hundred, it will now be time to send them out [to] Saint Francis of Assisi, and in a few years Rabelais. They would love and appreciate both better than we do, of our century. They liked Aristophanes when some years ago I tried to translate to them the dialogue between the farmer and his son, out of 'The Clouds'. In twenty years they might be ready for the Encyclopaedists, and then they would come, in another ten years, to Kipling. We should let them have dreamers, philosophers, and poets out, to prepare the ground for Mr Ford.

Where shall they find us then? Shall we in the meantime have caught them by the tail and be hanging on to it, in our pursuit of some shade, some

darkness, practising upon a tomtom? Will they be able to have our motor cars at cost price then, as they now have the doctrine of Transubstantiation? (pp 251-252).

(b). from Mazrui's World Culture and the Black Experience (1974):

Ancient Egyptians were a part of the Nile Valley [and] Africa in a manner in which ancient Greece was not a part of north-western Europe. The first of all major civilizations, the Egyptian, was much more African than the Athenian civilization was Germanic or Nordic. Yet white writers with names like Potter [or Blixen], which are not even remotely Greek or Roman, revel in the heritage of Greece and Rome, while denying the African continent as a whole the right to revel in the achievements of Egypt (pp 70).



2.7 FURTHER READING

Huxley, Elspeth. The Flame trees of Thika. 1959

Ruark, Robert. Something of Value. 1955



2.8 SELF-TEST QUESTIONS

1. Name at least two prose works set in East Africa during the colonial period.
2. Enumerate some of the reasons given by European immigrants as to why they were superior to indigenous Africans.

LECTURE THREE

EAST AFRICAN PIONEER PROSE WRITERS



3.1 INTRODUCTION

In the previous lecture, we talked about prose writing in or about East Africa during the colonial days. With time, indigenous Africans from East Africa learnt how to read and write. Logically, the earliest writing by indigenous people of East Africa was a direct response to the writings we discussed in lecture two. Towards the end of lecture one, I gave you a sampling of early East African prose writers and some of their prose titles. You have no doubt read some of the novels and short stories by now. In this lecture I will talk generally about some of the pioneer writers and their novels and short stories.



3.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Understand the origins of written literature in East Africa.
- Discuss the influence of European literature on early prose writing in East Africa.
- Show that writers from East Africa draw on the oral tradition and local cultural practices to enrich their narratives.
- Recognise some character types in early East African prose writing.



3.3 PIONEER WRITERS

The first crop of indigenous prose writers from East Africa include Aniceti Kitereza (Tanzania), Shaaban Roberts (Tanzania), Peter Palangyo (Tanzania), Grace Ogot (Kenya), Ngugi wa Thiong'o (Kenya), Okello Oculi (Uganda), Robert Serumanga (Uganda) and Saverio Naigiziki (Rwanda).

These writers were products of the colonial education system. It was by attending mission schools established by Christian missionaries during the colonial era that these indigenous Africans learnt the skill of writing. In the process, they also learnt the language(s) of the coloniser(s).

Aniceti Kitereza may be the oldest of these writers. He was the grandson of King Machunda of the Silanga clan and was born in 1896 on the island of Ukerewe in Tanzania. He started school in 1905 in the Kagunguli Village Roman Catholic Mission School, proceeding to the Rubya Roman Catholic Seminary near Kagera. He studied theology and philosophy, but he also learnt Latin, Greek, German, Kiswahili and (after Germany's defeat in the First World War) English.

Shaaban Robert, also of Tanzania, is regarded as one of the greatest writers in the Kiswahili language. Robert was born in 1909 in Vibamba in the Tanga region. Between 1922 and 1926 he was educated in Dar es Salaam, emerging second best in his class. On attaining his school certificate he became a civil servant in the colonial administration. His experiences are woven

into his fiction. As is demonstrated by his name, Shaaban Robert had equal respect for Muslims and Christians. He was a humanist who contributed immensely to the struggle for the dignity of mankind. He contributed to the promotion of the Kiswahili language, but his books are readily available in English translation.

Next in line comes Ngugi wa Thiong'o. Ngugi was born in 1938 in Limuru, Kenya. He was taught by Carey Francis at Alliance High School. As a student at Makerere University College he edited *Penpoint*, a periodical published by the Department of English. In 1964 he graduated with honours in English. He worked briefly for *Daily Nation* and was the editor of *Zuka: A Journal of East African Creative Writing* before proceeding to University of Leeds for graduate studies. His literary career extends to short stories, plays and journalism.

Grace Ogot was born in Asembo, Nyanza district. She trained as a nurse in Uganda and in England. She has worked as a midwife, as a tutor, as a journalist, as an Overseas Service broadcaster for the British Broadcasting Service (BBC), and in a managerial capacity for the Air India Corporation of East Africa. In 1984 she became one of only a handful of women to serve as a Member of Parliament and the only woman assistant minister in the cabinet of then President Daniel arap Moi. Ogot has since held various Ambassadorial posts, representing Kenya at the United Nations and UNESCO. Ogot was a founding member of the Writers' Association of Kenya. Her writing style is splendid in its evocation of vivid imagery; she captures the formalities of traditional African interpersonal exchanges, governed by protocol and symbolism. Many of her stories are set against the scenic background of Lake Victoria and the traditions of the Luo people. Her prose is evocative of traditional folklore— such as in *The Strange Bride*, a novel about a mystical and provocative female character in ancient Luoland.

Taban lo Liyong was born in 1939. He grew up in northern Uganda where he attended Gulu High School and Sir Samuel Baker School. Upon graduating from National Teachers' College, Kampala, he was awarded two scholarships. He studied in the United States and became the first African to attend the University of Iowa Writers' Workshop. Between 1969 and 1970, lo Liyong produced three volumes: *The Last Word*, *Fixions* and *Eating Chiefs*. *The Last Word* was the first book of literary criticism to be published in East Africa. Lo Liyong was one of the most prolific, candid, and controversial African men of letters, declaring East Africa a "literary desert" in 1965.

As is to be expected, the pioneer East African writers lived among their own people before they started school. They knew and practiced the traditional African way of life in their respective villages. They understood and appreciated the way of life of their people. When they went away to Christian boarding schools, they had to learn to live a totally different life. It was like growing up twice. Eventually they grew, Like Waiyaki in Ngugi's The River Between, to understand and appreciate both cultures. They could see that the immigrant Europeans had misunderstood the African way of life. When the indigenous Africans started to write, therefore, they were intent, in the first instance, on responding to the prevailing untruths and distortions of African culture and traditions.

Kitereza's famous 1945 novel, Myombekere na Bugonoka na Ntulanalwo na Bulihwali, is written in Kikerewe. An English translation is not readily available. Ngugi's Weep Not, Child was the first novel in English to be published by an East African writer. The title seems like a phrase addressed to the first generation of educated Africans by way of consolation for the feelings of resentment aroused by what had been written about Africa by "others." In his second novel, Ngugi wa Thiong'o further explores the traditional way of life. Indeed, The River Between, published in 1965, was written before Weep Not, Child. Consequently, the events it describes relate to an earlier time. The overall message of The River Between, after describing the traditional way of life and the beginnings of Christianity, seems to be that the Africans should return to older values. The reader gets the feeling that evolution of the preexisting culture is the preferred method of change, and integration with a foreign culture will inevitably lead to tragedy.

Eric Sikujua's short story 'Ivory Bangles' delivers more or less the same message: that departing from the established order brings tragedy. 'Ivory Bangles' describes the death of a woman. What is significant about this death is that we are made to believe that the only reason it happens is because the woman and her husband disobey the seer. Indeed, the powers of the seer seem to be affirmed. In a village of many families, he seems to know in advance that this one woman will die. He even knows how to prevent the death, and informs the husband in advance. In turn, the husband tells his wife. The husband agonises over the seer's message and decides that the proposed remedy is better than death. He seems ready to carry out the instructions of the seer. Ironically, it is the wife who talks him out of it. In the end, her attempt to cheat destiny and the seer leads to her death.

The short story 'The Bamboo Hut' by Grace Ogot, expertly presents unpolluted Africa. It is a story about the elemental human passions of power, love, fear and conquest, with a distinctly African flavour. It presents a benevolent chief whose main concern is that all the people in his community should be happy.

3.4 CHARACTERISATION

The main characters in the early East African prose writing are indigenous Africans. Roberts' Kusadikika has a main character whose name is Kirima. The name of the main character in Dying in the Sun is Ntanya. In Return to the Shadows, the name of the main character is Joe Musizi. The name of the character depends on the community the character comes from. A character whose mother tongue is Kikuyu may have the name Waiyaki, a name which in the past was associated with power and leadership among the Kikuyu people. In Tanzania, the name Nguvumali comes up in several stories. According to Hasani Bin Ismail's ballad "Swifa ya Nguvumali," Nguvumali was the name of a medicine man. The medicine man was regarded by some people as a fraud, while others believed that he was possessed by magical powers.

Many of the other characters are also Africans. In The River Between, other key characters who have African names are Muthoni and Nyambura. In A Grain of Wheat, there are four characters

among whom it is not easy to distinguish a main character: Gikonyo, Mugo, Karanja and Mumbi. In Ogot's 'Bamboo Hut,' characters have names that are easily associated with the shores of Lake Victoria: Achieng, Awiti, and Owiny.

In some cases, the characters are presented as "types" and their names not given. There are benevolent kings, peaceful chiefs, brave warriors, revered seers, venerated fathers, loving mothers, obedient children and helpful neighbours. All of them live in harmony with one another and with nature. For instance, in Bosco's short story 'Ivory Bangles,' the setting is a traditional African village. There is a chief. The chief has a council of elders. There is a seer. The seer is respected and consulted when a problem arises. Polygamy is practised. A man is not allowed to have only one wife. Furthermore, the man must beat his wives from time to time. Failure to do so is considered disobedience and must be punished. The plot is so typical that the characters have no names: they are types.



3.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture we have discussed the earliest prose writing by East African writers. We have noted that these young African men and women were taught how to read and write in the Christian mission schools. As they picked up the art of reading and writing, they also picked up the coloniser's language. They realised that many of the things that had been written and said about their traditional African communities were not true. In writing, they set out to correct those untruths and to rehabilitate their demeaned past. Early East African prose writing includes many stories which are set in traditional Africa before the arrival of European immigrants.



3.6 ACTIVITY

Read the excerpt below, taken from Grace Ogot's 'The Bamboo Hut.' Note down the details of setting. Using the details noted, write a description of the geographical and temporal setting.

The seFng sun was ablaze, and its angry rays coloured the waters on Lake Victoria. Mboga's heart beat fast. He had never seen the disc of the seFng sun look so big and ominous. He moved towards the foot of the sacred Hill of

Ramogi where his forefathers had from time immemorial worshipped God and pleaded with the ancestors.

For many years Mboga had beseeched Ramogi, the ancestor of the Luo people, to intercede on his behalf for a son, an heir to the beaded stool of the Kadibo people. He had decided to make one final plea on this sacred spot. He spat in the direction of the seFng sun, and then prayed.

...

The dismay in the homestead, when the news became known, may well be imagined. But all the uncles, aunts and other relatives agreed with the chief that Awiti would not make a suitable wife for Mboga's son. Only Achieng, Awiti's mother, knew the truth. Was she to die with this secret? Her son's life was at stake – why not face the chief and tell him the truth? She might ruin his life – but he was old enough to die. Her son had all his life before him. She made up her mind – she must say it.

She went to the chief's hut and fell at his feet weeping.

"She is my daughter. Awiti is the daughter of the great chief, and twin sister of Owiny, your son. I abandoned her by the well because I wanted to give you nothing but a son."

Mboga sat still and the hairs on his skin stood erect like those of a frightened cat. The scene on the path from the sacred hill when Awiti greeted him by the road side came to his mind. Yes, her face resembled that of his son. Mboga looked past his wife into the dark night. Only a few hours more and it would be sunrise, then the whole land would know the truth. He knew his people were going to persuade him to send Achieng away. She had thrown away her new born baby, she had angered the ancestors, she was not worthy of being a chief's wife.

But Mboga made up his mind. No one was going to take Achieng from him. She was the centre of his life. The self-doubt that often follows the betrayal of life-long trust crept into Mboya's mind. He wondered what other secrets were hidden in the bosoms of his wives. He lifted Achieng's head from his feet.

"Mother of Awiti, arise. For my sake you have borne a heavy burden for many years. You have denied yourself the pleasure a mother gets from seeing her child. Go and tell your son that he has a very beautiful sister. I shall give him my choicest bull to slaughter and eat with his sister and friends – let us all rejoice and thank our ancestor Ramogi!"



3.7 FURTHER READING

Zirimu, Pio and Andrew Gurr, eds. Black Aesthetics, Papers from a Colloquium held at the UoN in June 1971. Nairobi: East African Literature Bureau, 1971.



3.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

1. Explain the significance of novels like The River Between and short stories like 'The Bamboo Hut' in the study of East African prose writing.

LECTURE FOUR

STYLE AND NARRATIVE TECHNIQUES



4.1 INTRODUCTION

In the last lecture I talked generally about pioneer East African prose writers and some of their works. We talked about the acquisition of a European language in school. We saw that when the first crop of indigenous African writers began to write, they wanted to provide their own version of life and people in East Africa to counter some of the inaccuracies they had come across in works written by European immigrants. In this lecture I will talk about the way in which they did this: their style and narrative techniques.



4.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

1. Identify the distinguishing stylistic features of early East African prose fiction.
2. Explain the historical reasons that made the early East African writers choose to write that way.
3. Discuss the advantages and disadvantages of their choice of narrative techniques.



4.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

Many of the early East African novels and short stories were written while the writers were still students. Perhaps predictably, their tone was sentimental and self-righteous. They found themselves alone and lonely in strange cities or countries. They remembered with nostalgia their families in their home villages. When they wrote, it was partly for consolation. They wrote about their own homes and villages. They wrote in English or French, but the characters in their fiction had the names of their relatives: Njoroge, Atieno, Tumaini.

These characters, leading the traditional life in rural Africa, did not speak English or French. For each community, there was a language, and a way of life. Each writer, not having lived outside his own community prior to going for further studies, could only document the life of his own people. Ngugi's Weep Not, Child, for instance, is divided into two parts: the first part deals with the period just before the Emergency in Kenya; the second with the effects of the Emergency on the lives of a family in the Central Kenya Highlands.

Although the narrative is in English or French, the characters are assumed to speak their own mother tongue: Njoroge from the Kenya highlands speaks Kikuyu while Atieno from the lakeshore speaks Dholuo. Proverbs and other stylistic devices of the mother tongue are therefore first rendered in the vernacular before the writer provides an English or French equivalent.



4.3.1 SYMBOLISM AND OTHER FEATURES OF STYLE

African names are the immediately obvious feature in early East African prose fiction. In some instances, names may give readers an idea of character.

‘TRANSITION’

This is the title of a short story by Peter John Bosco. It describes the dilemma of a conservative man, Amri, who does not wish to change his ways even when most others from his village have done so. He fears that the communal farming in Ujamaa villages will soon fail and people will be forced to return to the traditional small-holder subsistence agriculture. His wife, Taabu, tries to make him change his mind and join the others in the Ujamaa village. His son, Tumaini, also tries to talk to him. In the end, it is as if nature conspires with them against him. His home, possessions and food stores are washed away in a fierce storm, and he is lucky that no one in his family dies. If he moves, it is only because he has nothing left and no one supports him. This story is symbolic of the new East African states. At first, it was expected that life would continue as it had been lived before the coloniser came. Eventually, it became clear that it was necessary to make psychological and physical adjustments. Those who refused to change perished.

There are other symbols in early East African prose fiction. Water is universally accepted as a symbol of life. Depending on how it is used, it can also be a symbol of destruction. Trees are significant features. Indeed, for the Kikuyu, a “mugumo” tree is an indication of a sacred site. Huge rocks, hills and mountains also tend to be related to religious beliefs and associated with religious practices. When Mboga prays desperately for a son in Ogot’s ‘Bamboo Hut,’ for example, he goes to the foot of Ramogi hill.

Cultural practices are another important feature in East African prose fiction. There are ceremonies for naming a new born, there are circumcision initiation ceremonies, there are marriage ceremonies, and there are elaborate death rituals. Smaller details include fetching water or firewood, plaiting hair, herding, hoeing and cooking. There are numerous examples of references to the human body. Indeed, Doris finds that unlike writing from other parts of the world, East African writing has an “utterly firm grounding in a healthy, sensible attitude toward the human body and natural functions.”

In Ogot’s short story ‘The Old White Witch,’ the whole conflict arises out of the instructions given by the new matron that nurses should carry bed pans. The nurses in this part of the world believe that if they do so, they will not find suitors for marriage.



4.4 NARRATIVE TECHNIQUES

In the earliest East African prose fiction, the narrative followed a linear pattern where the story starts at the beginning, and follows the chronological occurrence of events to the end. This is the usual order for oral narratives, which had been a feature of African culture long before the written word took root. For example, the oral style of rendition is conspicuous in Margaret Ogola's The River and the Source; references to myth have been made in Weep Not Child. In addition to form, some of the material in the novels and short stories is drawn from the oral tradition. In particular, proverbs and songs are a common feature.

With time and experience the narrative techniques became more complex and varied. Additional narrative techniques include the following:

Interior characterisation. Stream

of consciousness.

Flashbacks. For example in The River Between when Waiyaki is thinking about Muthoni, and the trip to and from the hospital.

Satire in Ngugi's Devil on the Cross and in much of Wahome Mutahi's work.

The collective first person as in Ngugi's Petals of Blood, which is also structured as a detective story.

Magical realism. In the case of Ngugi's Wizard of the Crow, even the title is ambiguous. It could mean the one who bewitched the crow, or the wizard who is owned by the crow.

PUBLISHING

The earliest works by East African writers were published in Europe, or (in the case of short stories) in literary journals of the university colleges. With time, however, a local publishing industry developed. The East African Publishing House played a significant role in publishing the work of up-coming African writers, including those from East Africa. The closure of this publishing house in the 1980s was a major blow to literature in East Africa. Other publishing houses include Heinemann (now East African educational Publishers), Longman (now Longhorn), Oxford University Press and Macmillan.



4.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture I have talked about style and narrative techniques in East African prose writing. We have noted that the early writers purposefully set out to document the cultural landscape as they understood it as a way of responding to some of the perspectives adopted by European writers. We have noted that the initial style was simple and straightforward. We have also noted that narrative techniques have become more complex and varied with time.



4.6 ACTIVITY

Read the excerpt below, taken from 'Transition.' Make a note of the symbolic features. Using the notes you have made, explain how the short story 'Transition' can be read as an allegory of any of the East African nations.

In a few moments the house was in commotion. Everyone was carrying out of the hut what he could lay hands on: mats, baskets, pots, bits of clothing, implements. The roof of the hut gaped open in the middle and sagged dangerously over their heads. Rain flooded into the hut. Taabu was shouting at the children to keep out of the way. Just as Amri was dragging out the large earthen pot, the last item remaining in the hut, the roof collapsed, bringing down two of the walls with it. At once, a swirling torrent hit at the remaining walls which, like melting wax, yielded to its erosive power and collapsed in a heap. The relentless drops of rain pelted at the prostrate walls and little by little carried them away as chunks of mud.

Amri and the family clustered together in the streaming rain. Lightning flashed and thunder rocked the earth they stood on. A few paces from where they stood something heavy fell with a dull thud. When lightning flashed again they saw their granary being slowly washed down the hill in a strong current. The goats bleated and the cows lowed in their byre. And now the deep rumbling

mourning of the thunder caught hold of them too, and the fear of the dark night and the storm assailed their hearts.

Tumaini found himself standing beside his father. He peered at his face and in the flash of lightning saw the defeat in his eyes. Tumaini was suddenly filled with compassion. He braced his shoulders and resolved to stand by him through the hazards of the night and together with him await the break of a new day.

To cross the river, as wide and deep
That 'tween opposing worlds doth sweep,
To jump across with one clear leap It
never once shall be as cheap.
But must always a storm them force,
The strong-willed ones that are loath to cross?



4.7 FURTHER READING

Ogot, Grace. 'The old white witch.' In Land Without Thunder.

Ole Kulet, H. R. To Become a Man. Nairobi: Longhorn Publishers, 1972.



4.8 SELF-TEST QUESTIONS

1. How has the term transition been used in this chapter in relation to East African prose fiction?
2. Give the names of at least three characters in the short story 'Transition' by Peter John Bosco.

THEMES AND THEORETICAL CONCERNS



5.1 INTRODUCTION

In the last lecture I talked about the style and narrative techniques employed in East African prose writing. For all five countries, political independence came in the early 1960s. There was the expectation that the new African leaders would bring positive change to their communities and to the country as a whole. After the first few years of self rule, however, the masses and the writers finally acknowledged betrayal: the new crop of African leaders did not bring freedom or prosperity as expected. In many cases, the general populace was actually worse off with the African leaders than they had been with the European colonists. The ensuing disappointment, disillusionment and bitterness are captured in the literature. These are some of the concerns I will talk about in this lecture.



5.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Highlights themes common to early East African prose fiction
- Differentiate East African prose fiction written after several years of self rule from earlier prose fiction.
- Discuss the disappointment of the general populace with the first crop of African leaders as it is captured in literature.
- Trace the shift in author's perspective from that of national spokesperson to that of a critic of the ruling elite.



5.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

Some themes have featured in East African literature from the very beginning. Of the earliest themes, the most notable include education, the struggle for freedom, religion and independence. Other themes have become manifest after the first few years of self rule at which point creative writers begin to identify more with the masses and less with the ruling elite. Together with the general populace, writers are disappointed with the ruling elite. The creative writing, therefore, begins to have protagonists who are not members of the ruling elite. In some instances, the protagonist has been directly involved in ushering in the new leadership, sometimes at great personal cost. When the new leadership fails, therefore, his sense of betrayal is deeper than that of others.

The general plot follows more or less the reality that the writers have lived through. During the struggle for independence, they wrote to encourage and empower the general populace to participate in the struggle. On the eve of independence, they wrote cautiously of where the future seemed likely to lead. The African leaders were expected to mobilise resources to fight the three enemies of poverty, ignorance and disease. Once the African ruling elite settled into office, however, it was clear that they had had very different plans from other members of the community. Instead of mobilising resources for the benefit of the whole country, they were more interested in self aggrandisement. To achieve their goals, they used public resources to reward individuals in the process of consolidating power.



5.4 THEMES

Nature

Nature is a prevalent theme in early East African prose fiction. The setting is almost always rural. The traditional way of life which is documented in the early prose fiction is regulated by the seasons. For the sedentary communities relying on agriculture for subsistence, the rainy season means a flurry of planting and weeding activities. The harvesting is done in the dry season. In the event of a drought, all systems come to a standstill and the community goes into emergency mode.

Family Life

Related to the theme of nature is that of family life. In most of the early accounts, the family unit is complete with a father, a mother and several children. In some instances, there are several mothers. In retrospect, while studying in a foreign country, the young African writers' memory of family life pointed at a clear division of labour: the womenfolk did the chores around the house and shambas; the men hunted, went to market and held meetings to make

decisions for the family and the community as the need may be. If a long journey had to be undertaken, it was a man who undertook it.

Cultural Practices

Cultural practices are incorporated into the narrative. The key ceremonies are the naming of a new born, the circumcision ceremony and marriage celebrations. Each community has a unique way of celebrating these events, and these are documented in the prose fiction. Indeed, there is a work in prose fiction titled "To Become a Man."

Formal Education

African societies had traditional methods of transmitting culture and information from one generation to the next. These methods involved complex systems and structures. With the advent of colonialism, these systems and structures fell apart and lost their effectiveness. The formal school system introduced by the coloniser became the new way of effectively transmitting culture and knowledge. The theme of education takes many forms. Some characters are forced by their parents to go to school. Others run away from home in order to go to school against the wishes of their parents. Many are torn between the desire to remain in the village and continue belonging and the thirst for knowledge.

Religion

The European coloniser brought to Africa the Christian religion. Many Africans were converted into the Christian faith. In East Africa, missionaries came from Britain, France, Ireland, Scotland, and Germany. Conversions took place depending on the mission that was closest to a village or settlement. The centre of the mission was a church, a school and with time, a health facility. All the African children who went to school to get a formal education went to mission schools. They had to convert to the Christian faith to proceed with their education. Most converted automatically in order to proceed with their education. However, it was difficult to root out the traditional beliefs of their people. They had been born into traditional African societies and had seen performed and practised certain ceremonies which had become a part of themselves. The early literature produced by indigenous Africans deals with some of these issues. With the knowledge they acquired, they began to compare the theory to the practice. They could see certain discrepancies. Below is one interesting observation:

...We are the true Christ. Christ, the missionaries have told us, was the man of sorrows; but the missionaries have not experienced these sorrows. Whereas our sufferings, under slavery and colonialism give us the unique moral authority, the representative, redemptive force, which the Christian myth confers upon suffering.' Angus Calder, in 'An open letter to Pio Zirimu,' 1971.

Clash between traditional African values and those of the coloniser

Along with the religion were cultural practices which had nothing to do with matters of faith, but which the coloniser insisted upon, so that convertees were made to feel that adopting those

practices made them better Christians. In practising the new habits, they had to let go of some of their old ones. The most hotly contested of the traditional practices was female circumcision. It is still an issue in the twenty-first century. Another practice was polygamy. It, too, continues to be an issue in the twenty-first century. It is highly unlikely that a circumcised girl who wishes to convert to the Christian faith in 2010 will be denied the privilege by any of the Christian churches registered to practice in East Africa. But a man who professes the Christian faith is allowed only one wife. For the conservative churches, divorce is not an option and remarriage after civil divorce is not permitted. These two issues were key themes in early East African prose fiction. The result of trying to mix the two was usually tragic.

Ngugi's first written, second published book, The River Between, documents the dilemma faced by the first generation of educated Christian Africans. There is the tragedy of Muthoni, who does not understand why as a Christian she can not also get circumcised and become "beautiful in the tribe." She dies trying. The case of Waiyaki is worse. He is intelligent enough to see that there are positive aspects in each culture, but the players on the two sides are too conservative to accept him as a hybrid of the two cultures.

Alienation

As mentioned earlier, spending time at the mission school had the effect of alienating African children. They could no longer participate in the day-to-day events happening at home within their communities. They converted to the Christian faith. They acquired skills which were of no use and had no value in their villages. These realities are captured in creative writing. Many of the educated African elite became "children of two worlds" who could not fit comfortably in either of their worlds.

Tension

As a result of the changes that were happening in both the domestic and public spheres, there was anxiety and restlessness. In the first instance, there was tension between the coloniser and the colonised. There are also tensions between tribes, clans, families, individuals and even within the individual. Some of these tensions are expertly captured in Jonathan Kariara's short story 'The Coming of Power.' On the surface, it is the story of supplying electricity to one rural community. The villagers, who have never had electricity and are not aware of its benefits, are opposed to the project, especially because the power lines must pass through their lands. In addition to the question of power and land, there are fascinating undercurrents, as the following extract shows:

"the thing that is coming – it can do all that!" Festus Gichuki exclaimed, his mouth a regular O. "And what will be left for our women to do?" The rest of the party coughed genteelly, knowing that the doctor was back in the water once more.

....

Loud laughter followed, for the men could not genuinely conceive of such a marvel. Women in the village would rebel if their deft hands were denied the satisfaction of seeing the potato peel curling as their quick fingers worked on the vegetable, each newly peeled potato joining a growing mound in a sufuria half-filled with water.

....

"But you've always told us that the mission was the light to light our darkness. How come we need another light?" King'ong'o asked, scratching his head.

"There is no need to play the child, Mannasseh. Your daughter's a nurse in Nairobi. Ask her about electricity and she'll tell you." They had all been to Nairobi and marvelled at its never being night in the city. As one awed visitor had assured the rest of the villagers after such a journey: "You can extract a jigger from your small toe in Nairobi without asking anyone to hold the lamp for you – so bright are the lights there." The idea of permanent 'daylight' was oddly pleasing to them, as if one of their childhood terrors had been dispelled.

...

"You're hasty there, Bwana Musa," Yakubu added before Dr Macregor could respond. "The power line does not come through our land at all. There is already power at Kigwa-ini; the line passes not two miles from here. Why doesn't the mission take power from that?"

...

The men now faced the harder task of convincing their wives that any good would come of any of the continuous mad schemes the men landed on them; if in taking power to the mission the crops got trampled underfoot and there was famine, who would finally be blamed but the woman's laziness?



5.4.1 THEORETICAL CONCERNS

Knowledge of historical and social realities is essential to any understanding of East African Literature. Critics should have an awareness of the cultures of the African people, their way of reasoning and their attitudes towards different situations in life. The post colonial literary theory applies to much of East African prose writing. In addition to trying to set the record straight as far as the traditional African way of life was concerned, writers also documented the struggle by the Africans for freedom from colonial domination. In the case of Kenya and Tanzania, the hostilities escalated to full-blown armed conflict.

THE MAJI MAJI REBELLION

This was a violent African resistance to colonial rule in the German colony of Tanganyika lasting from 1905 to 1907. A spirit medium named Kinjikitile Ngwale claimed to be possessed by a snake spirit called Hongo. Ngwale began calling himself Bokero and developed a belief that the people of German East Africa had been called upon to eliminate the Germans. German anthropologists recorded that he gave his followers war medicine that would turn German bullets into water. This "war medicine" was in fact water (*maji* in Kiswahili) mixed with castor oil and millet seeds. Empowered with this new liquid, Bokero's followers began what would become known as the Maji Maji Rebellion. They were numerous and believed that they could not be harmed because the German's bullets would turn to water. The MajiMaji rebellion left more than three hundred thousand people dead, among them fifteen Europeans.

THE MAU MAU

The acronym MAU MAU refers to a militant African nationalist movement active in Kenya during the 1950s. The main aim of the movement was to remove British rule and European settlers from the country. At the beginning of 1956, it was estimated that the colonial administration had killed more than ten thousand MAU MAU operatives and supporters. For their part, the MAU MAU targeted the European farmers and their supporters, especially local chiefs and home guards. Indeed, these two terms feature prominently in early East African prose fiction.

MARXISM

The Marxist ideology has also had an influence on East African prose fiction. Marxists see society's problems as emanating from a struggle between the rich and the poor, between the "bourgeoisie" [capitalists] and the "proletariat" [workers]. Writers were disappointed by the behaviour of the African ruling elite. They realised that the majority had been blinded by their euphoria over independence. When they finally put pen to paper, after the initial shock and disappointment, it was to bitterly castigate the ruling elite for their selfish behaviour. Ngugi's Petals of Blood is an example of a novel with a Marxist bent.



5.4.2 PETALS OF BLOOD

Ngugi's Petals of Blood is a classic indictment of the post independence African ruling elite. Indeed the names of the three characters who represent this class in the novel are highly symbolic. Kimeria is the representative in government (Member of Parliament) of the people

of Ilmorog. His character is that of a hyena which 'devours' young school girls, money, land, factories and anything else that crosses his path with ruthless abandon. Chui is a failed intellectual turned industrialist who thrives on corruption and other unorthodox business practices. Mzigo is an educationist who spends more time intimidating junior officers and fleeing the populace than implementing education policies.

Petals of Blood is essentially a detective story. At the beginning Munira, Karega and Abulla are picked up from their respective homes by the police for "routine questioning." The mystery is then announced as a newspaper headline "Mzigo, Chui, Kimeria murdered." The rest of the novel is dedicated to helping the reader manoeuvre his way through the closely interwoven histories of otherwise total strangers to the perpetrator and, more significantly, to the reasons behind the crime.

The novel is divided into four parts. Each part has a sub-title. Taken together, the sub-titles form the sentence "Walking towards Bethlehem to be born again ... la lotta continua." This is an unmistakable allusion to Christian mythology. There are other allusions, to other parts of the world. This seems to suggest that what is being described is not peculiar to that particular time and place. It has happened elsewhere.

Symbolism

Going by the biblical quotation from the book of revelation, it would seem that Ngugi sees his story as ushering in the moment of apocalypse, not only because Revelations is associated with it but also because of the balance in the hands of the rider of the black horse, which Ngugi significantly quotes only in part, as if to suggest that what the novel contains is the judgement rendered.

The novel Petals of Blood is set up as an epic story, and Ngugi draws the reader's attention to the journey by the way he presents it. The epic journey forms part two of the novel, and is suspended somewhere between chapter six, which ends part one, and chapter seven, which starts part three. It is given the title "the journey" and is framed by Munira's confessional prison notes.

For Munira, the trek across the plains is the beginning of an inward journey which leads him from the fringes to the centre of action, to the position from which he can now see that man's estate is rotten at heart (118). The journey infuses Karega with enthusiasm to study the past to better understand the present. To Abdulla it is a grim reminder of other journeys, other disappointments. And It takes Wanja back to the city, "mingling her consciousness of the hurt hurt she has suffered in the past with her awareness of the wasteland that surrounds her in the present" (Gikandi 143).

Ngugi makes use of other symbols in the novel which become an integral part of the story. For instance, at the beginning, the farmers of Ilmorog talk fearfully of a possible drought. It turns out that they had correctly interpreted the signs. The drought eventually comes. There is

hunger, restlessness and anger. The people confront their member of parliament (MP). He pays his constituency a visit. Ilmorog becomes urbanised. The drought, however, is not just a physical phenomenon. It is a graphic representation of the spiritual deprivation that has become rampant in the country and in East Africa. According to Munira “We went on a journey to the city to save Ilmorog from the drought. We brought back spiritual drought from the city.” The drought also represents the economic hardships that the peasants face.

The title “Petals of Blood” introduces both the flower and blood as symbols. A lot of African blood was spilled during the struggle for independence. The shedding of this blood, however, did bear fruit, when the East African countries got independence. The thrust of the message in the novel is that if more blood must be spilled for justice to be done, so be it.

The following key themes are dealt with in Petals of Blood:

Hypocrisy

When the delegation visits their MP in Nairobi, we get a glimpse into the hypocrisy and vulgarity of a self-styled “African bourgeoisie.” Kimeria is the hypocrite par excellence. He has a model family as a shield for his immoral activities. He blithely makes promises which he has absolutely no intention of keeping. Instead of trying to assist his constituents in their hour of need, he sees their plight as an opportunity to further enrich himself and secretly plans how to steal land and other resources from them.

Exploitation

This is one of the things Karega is trying to fight against when he joins the trade union movement. He has come to realise, through personal experience and minute observation, that those in power use every means possible to exploit the poor. It is something that bothers Munira as well, and this is one of the reasons he does not live at home with his father, Ezekiel, who exploits the peasants by invoking the tenets of the Christian faith.

Exploitation of the poor by the rich means that the gap between the poor and the rich is widening. Those who have taken over from the colonists are rich. They live in big houses in the city or in the suburbs, houses previously occupied by the departed colonists. They drive expensive cars imported from the countries of the former colonists. They have directorships in foreign-owned multinational corporations. They have also taken over ownership of the previously alienated farms. By contrast, the peasants continue to own small, unproductive pieces of land on which they eke out a subsistence using traditional methods of cultivation. All of the main characters in Petals of Blood are poor, landless and have no say in the decision-making process. Many of them were actively engaged in the fight for freedom.

Dependency Syndrome

The economic and socio-political state of affairs described in Petals of Blood is common in those countries referred to as “third world countries.” The members of the ruling elite seem to be

doing well and they make it a point to lead a lifestyle defined by conspicuous consumption. The majority of the population, however, whether in the rural areas or in the city, is steeped in abject poverty. In the rural areas, poverty is visible in lack of food, clothes, shoes and even shelter. In the urban areas, poverty is visible in crowded living spaces and poor sanitation. The worst part of this is the feeling we get that things will not change anytime soon. Those who are poor have the wrong mentality. They look up to the ruling elite to bring them out of poverty. They seem not to understand their role in getting themselves out of poverty. They seem to lack the intelligence to explore other options. The ruling elite capitalises on this to exploit them farther.



5.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture I have talked about some key themes and theoretical concerns in early East African prose fiction. We have noted that the early themes of nostalgia for traditional Africa, education and alleviation of disease, ignorance and poverty, slowly gave way to disillusionment with the ruling class. As creative writers began to distance themselves from the ruling elite in favour of the masses, the tone of their writing became sarcastic and bitter. Within a relatively short period of time, the prevailing mood went from indignant, through hope and expectation, to disappointment and betrayal. In the remaining lectures we shall discuss contemporary themes. Once creative writers dissociated themselves from the ruling elite, they also became less engaged in national causes and more involved in human affairs at a personal level.



5.6 ACTIVITY

The following extract from 'A Mercedes Funeral'. Note the key words and phrases used to describe the Member of Parliament. Using those key words/phrases and your general knowledge, draw up a character portrait of a typical African politician:

...the most Honourable John Joe James... would you believe it...dropped his African name on first being elected – standards, efficiency and international dignity demanded it ...

The three were however united in denouncing the siFng member. What had he done for the area? He had only enriched himself and his relatives. They pointed to his business interests, his numerous buildings in the area and his many shares in even the smallest petrol station in the constituency. From what forgotten corner had he suddenly acquired all that wealth, including a thousand-acre farm, asked the aspiring businessman? Why had he not given others a democratic chance to dip a hand in the common pool? The student demanded: what has he done for us wafanyi kazi? The ex-chief accused him of never once visiting his constituency. His election had been a one-way ticket to the city. They all chorused: let the record speak, let the record speak for itself. Funnily enough, gentlemen, the incumbent replied with the same words – yes, let the record speak – but managed to give them a tone of achievement. First he pointed out what the Government had done: the roads, hospitals, factories, tourist hotels and resorts, Hilton, the Intercontinental and all that. Anybody who said the Government had done nothing for wananchi was demagogic and indulging in cheap politics. To the charge that he was not a minister and hence was not in Government, he would laugh and fly-whisk away such ignorance. From where did the Government derive its strength and power? From among whom was the cabinet chosen? To the charge that he had made it, he answered by accusing the others of raging with envy and congenital idleness. A national cake on the table ... some people too lazy or too fat to lift a finger and take a piece ... waited to have it put into their mouths and chewed for them, even...

...

Now everyone waited for J. J. J. His six years in parliament had made him an accomplished actor. He took his time. His leather briefcase with bulging papers was there; he collected his ivory walking stick and fly-whisk. His belly though big was right for his height. He talked about his long service and experience. People did not in the old days send an uncircumcised boy to lead a national army, he said, slightly glancing at the opponents ... He had always fought for the poor... But he would not bore people with a long talk on such a sad occasion. He did not want to bring politics into what was a human loss. All he wanted was not only to pay his respects to the dead but also to respect the wishes of the dead.



5.7 FURTHER READING

Re-read Part Two of Ngugi wa Thiong'o's Petals of Blood.



5.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

Discuss the journey motif in Ngugi's Petals of Blood.

LECTURE SIX URBANISATION, POVERTY AND CRIME



6.1 INTRODUCTION

You will remember from previous lectures that Africans looked forward to independence.

Their earliest prose fiction was therefore optimistic. The expectations of the general populace were that as soon as African government came to power, then all 'foreign' influences would be expunged from Africa. The policy of "Africanisation" did not just refer to replacing European rulers and other leaders with Africans. It was supposed to include a return to African practices and a new way of life that would give precedence and preference to African social structures and value systems. The subsequent disillusionment unleashed a wave of creative talent. Once writers broke ranks with the ruling class, they were free to be creative without trying to be politically correct. The 1980s and 1990s saw a proliferation of creative writing in East Africa. This golden age of creative talent in East Africa ushered in a whole new world in terms of setting, plot, style, characters and thematic concerns. In addition to themes discussed in the last lecture such as betrayal, greed, hypocrisy and alienation, other themes took on greater prominence. In this lecture we shall discuss the most obvious of those themes: Urbanisation.

6.2



LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Understand the genesis and process of urbanisation in the East African context.
- Discuss prose works which deal with the theme of urbanisation.
- Dissociate urbanisation from social ills which in East Africa have been historically associated with urbanisation.



6.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

You may have noticed that in the African context, urbanisation is often equated with Westernisation, or integration into the coloniser's way of life. Many stories will have sentences and scenarios which present people who live in towns as living "like Europeans." Modern conveniences like cars and electrical appliances are associated with towns. An affluent lifestyle is considered "European." Because they are associated with the colonial history, urban areas have always been cast in a negative light. The pioneer African writers set their novels and short stories in rural villages. These stories were intended to valorise the African past. The second and third generation of post-independence Africans have been weaned on these stories and hold an idealised view of the rural areas.

Nevertheless, we all know and appreciate that contemporary realities in East Africa involve life in rural villages as well as in urban centres. The population in urban centres is usually concentrated in a small area around the amenities of the city. What this means is that social realities become magnified because of this density of population. Furthermore, in urban centres there are people from the different parts of the country or the region. It is therefore possible for you to have neighbours whose mother tongue is different from yours. By extension, those neighbours who come from a different part of the country will also do things differently around the house. They come from a different 'home.' By some convoluted process of rationalisation, and thanks to the educative power of fiction, the collective psyche in East Africa believes that anything that is connected to rural life is purer and more blessed than anything that is connected to the urban areas, even though documented evidence proves otherwise.



6.4 URBANISATION

As I have said earlier, the reality in East Africa today is that life is split between rural areas and urban centres.

Indeed, a distinction is always made between rural 'home' and town 'house.' Everyone has a 'home' in the countryside. This is usually communal property which has been handed down through the generations. It is considered the 'ancestral home' where all family members will eventually be buried, so as to remain close even in death.

These are the homes people migrate from to come to urban centres, a phenomenon given the term 'rural-urban migration.' The traffic is usually one-way. For the most part, it is the young and strong adults who leave home in search of gainful employment in the cities. Sometimes, as in the case of the character in 'The Road to Mara,' the reasons may be personal. Nevertheless, the end result is the same. Once in the city, these strong young men and women stay on. If they live long enough to retire they may return to their rural homes. Some prefer to remain in the urban centres even in old age.

While in town, these young people start families of their own. Logically, the population in urban centres grows faster than that in rural areas. Life in the urban centres can not be the same as life in the rural areas. To start with, the rhythms of work are different. Paid employment is regulated by the clock and by the day, not by the seasons. Salaried employees do not own the houses in which they sleep after a day's work. Their lifestyle is such that they may never get to know their neighbours. These are the issues that are captured in the stories whose setting is urban.

As an increasing percentage of the population spends more time in urban areas, more and more stories have an urban setting. The hallmarks of the urban fiction are crowded living quarters, small rooms, poor sanitation, and a general lack of basic needs such as shelter, food and clothing. Hospitals are a luxury so rare that they rarely feature in fictional works. The major concerns of urban fiction can be summed up in two words: poverty and crime. Meja Mwangi's The Cockroach Dance captures the urban ethos quite well.

6.4.1 POVERTY AND CRIME

Generally speaking, the theme of poverty has been an integral part of written East African fiction from the beginning. To start with, in the agrarian subsistence economy, there was little with which to measure wealth other than livestock, wives and children, all of which are subject to the vagaries of nature. Furthermore, land and other natural resources were communally owned and shared, so it was not really necessary to assess an individual's worth.

Perhaps the most significant of all colonial legacies was the custom of using land as the ultimate status symbol. In this new value system, those without land are the poorest of the poor. Those who live in the rural areas have the security of the land on which they live. Stories with an urban setting are more likely to deal with the theme of poverty. In the absence of some form of social security, those without regular income, and whose relatives are unwilling to support them, are completely destitute. Today, we have in East Africa, people who live and raise families on the streets at the mercy of the elements.

Predictably, crime rates are higher in urban areas. When so many people, whose personal situations are so different one from another, are crowded into one small area, conflict is bound to arise. The greatest paradox of development in East Africa is that for every upmarket housing development, there is a parallel and nearby informal settlement. There is also the common variation where the well-to-do provide housing for their workers. Fiction with an urban setting will also include both groups of people. For instance, in Coming to Birth Paulina is housed by her employer. The downside of this housing benefit is that she has to work odd hours.

Generally when petty crime is committed, it is the poor who are the perpetrators. Sometimes it is a domestic worker cheating his or her employer out of small change. Sometimes it is a gang of highway robbers who hijack vehicles. These realities are reflected in fictional works.



6.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture, I have talked about urbanisation not only as a theme in East African Prose fiction but also as a concept which has been equated with Westernisation from the very beginning. Consequently, it has hindered development by deepening the schizophrenic nature of East Africans. None of us wants to be associated completely with urban areas because of our illogical belief that nothing good can come out of them. Paradoxically, more and more people find a livelihood in the urban areas and, therefore, more and more stories have an urban setting. In the next chapter we shall talk about relationships. In preparation, we shall read the story 'Moneyman,' which has an urban setting and touches on relationships.



6.6 ACTIVITY

Read the three excerpts below which relate to urbanisation. Note down the key words and phrases which are used to describe the urban areas.

From 'The Town' by Eneriko Seruma

The passengers got out of the cab, handing the fare to the driver. Each passenger, except he last one, disappeared into the crowd as soon as the change was handed back. The last passenger, a man who was a villager, stood some feet away from the car and watched the distant caller. 'And they like the town!' he thought. 'Instead of owning a small place in the village and farming for a better living, look at what they do. How can a man spend all day barking like a crazy dog?' He wondered how much the caller earned and walked over to the driver who was siFng in his car whistling to himself as he waited for passengers.

'How much does the caller earn?' he asked the driver.

'Fifty cents per car-load. That's some money, you know. About eight, nine, maybe even ten shillings a day. And that's earned without any manual labouring too.'

The man thanked the driver and moved away. 'Yes,' he thought, 'that's the trouble with town people: they are always afraid of manual labour. They don't realize that because I dig from sunrise to midday I can sell five to six bags of coffee for a lot of money, and I save because I don't have to buy food like they do. They spend all their money buying villagers' farm produce.' He took his eyes from the caller and walked away, squeezing among people of all sorts. 'What a gathering of characters!' he marvelled 'They are all like vultures over a carcass.'

The man wished he could shut off the noise of the crowd; it was maddening. Not even at weddings and feasts – or even drinking parties – had he heard so much noise. Everybody seemed to be shouting; the noise seemed as if a cloud was hanging over the park and was striking him with bolts of noise.

'Here, miss, over here! I have the latest style ...'

'Over here, good lady! I have the latest fashion ...'

'Natete! Natete! Passengers for Natete over here!'

'Here's a real nice cab. Over here, passengers, quick! It's comfortable; it has a radio; listen to your favourite songs as you go to Nakulabye.'

'This one is faster. You'll be there in a few minutes.'

'That's how they kill themselves,' the villager thought, 'driving fast as if bees were chasing them! Like that driver who brought me, how fast he had been driving – with one hand! One is safer in buses these days.' The man concluded his thoughts about the fast cars as other shouts hit his exhausted ears.

'Handkerchiefs! Handkerchiefs! Only forty cents, two for eighty cents. From your shilling you will be left with twenty cents for peanuts and popcorn. Two handkerchiefs for ...'

'Here, my lords, here! Pure woollen trousers for only thirty-five shillings. Only thirty-five shillings – cheaper than in the Asian shops. Here my...'

'Katwe, Kibuye, Najja. Passengers for Katwe, Kibuye. The bus has just left, so don't miss this chance of a faster arrival. Katwe ...'

The villager stood and stared in wonderment. 'This is too much! Do these men wake up in the morning and tell their wives they are going to work? Look at them, all shouting their heads off. What a way to earn a living!' He shook his head as two men rushed at him with yards of cloth on their arms. There were so many of them. 'how can they make money with such competition?'

From 'The Second Delivery' by Kyalo Mativo

...now that the mist was subsiding, his attention was gradually being demanded by advertisement boards flashing in blue, red, green and white lights, proclaiming their purity and quality as commodities in the service of man. As if to challenge these advertisements, hawkers, food sellers, newspaper boys, and of course beggars, rubbed against one another to draw the attention of possible customers. The quietness of the air was slowly transforming itself into the discordant noises and the chaotic chanting of these traders announcing their presence:

"Maandazi ... haya maandazi moto," cried the food sellers.

"Nation, Taifaleo," answered some newspaper boys.

"Standard, Baraza, Times," retorted yet others

"Saidia Maskini-Mungu," pleaded the beggars.

And from unidentified directions came the cup-tinkling of the coffeesellers, accompanied by cries of "Kahawa safi" ensuing from somewhere. By now Ndani could not hear himself think, he was becoming part of this cacophonous frenzy, ...

From 'The Road to Mara' by Tom Chacha

"Mara?" shouted the driver above the racket from the engine.

She nodded, climbing aboard, and went to sit in a vacant seat near the front. She sat up rather stiffly and looked about. On her right were seated three other passengers: an old man in a stained old coat, a woman of indeterminate age and a young man. The woman smiled. The young girl, feeling rather embarrassed, returned her smile. No word passed between them.

The young man's eyes shone with speculation. He leaned over and whispered, "This must be the girl we heard about, father." His tone was excited.

"Can't you keep your eyes off these girls?" the old man whispered back, in strong reproof. He eyed Bena covertly, frowned and bit his lower lip. He could not imagine how a young girl like Bena could travel alone without an elderly companion. The old man's eyes caught those of his wife; in that moment, he knew that she was thinking the same thing as himself.

"This is one of those modern spoiled girls," the old man seemed to be saying in grim disapproval. "She is probably going to be a prostitute in the town."

The woman, sensing the old man's thoughts, looked at Bena again. Her lips parted, but not in a smile this time – in mixed sympathy and embarrassment. To the wife, Bena was a symbol of shame to all respectable women. She seemed to her somehow outcast, without roots or bearings, having no tribal markings on her face. She did not wear the iron rings on her neck. Instead, she sported some imitation pearls. On her wrist the tribal multicoloured beads were replaced by a small nickel-plated watch.

"The towns are spoiling our girls," the wife murmured to her husband. "It is so," the old man sighed, nodding his head. "Soon the villages will be empty." The old man nodded again, unhappily.



6.7 FURTHER READING

Mailu, David. The Ayah. 1986.



6.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

Give three reasons why East Africans would rather be associated with their rural 'homes' than with urban areas.

LECTURE SEVEN

RELATIONSHIPS



7.1 INTRODUCTION

Welcome to lecture seven in the series ALT 200. In the last lecture I talked about urbanisation. We have seen that urbanisation acquired negative connotations because it is related to the colonial history of East Africa. With time, however, it is becoming clear that it is not urbanisation, per se, which engenders evil. Rather, it is people who choose to do evil, and they will do so no matter where they happen to be. In this lecture, I will talk about relationships, in both rural areas and urban areas, as portrayed in East African prose fiction.



7.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Identify various relationships featured in East African prose fiction
- Pick out these key relationships in samples of East African prose fiction
- Discuss those relationships and the main characters within the context of world culture



7.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

From the novels and short stories you have read so far, you have already noted that 'Relationships,' as a theme in East African prose fiction, takes many forms. There are all kinds of relationships. Many of the main characters, especially in earlier works, are men. These men have families. Usually the relationship between a man and his father defines his existence. If the relationship is healthy, it benefits the man in question. If the relationship is unhealthy, it becomes destructive.

The relationship between male characters and their mothers is also significant. Sometimes the mother is the lifeline of her son, especially if the father is not there. Many of the stories set in pre-independence days have characters whose fathers are in detention or have died heroic deaths in the struggle for 'Uhuru.' For these characters, the mothers take over the father's role of mentorship, with support from the characters' uncles. Naturally, there are relationships between men and women, either as sisters, wives or daughters. Then there are relationships between the men themselves. There are also, although they are fewer, relationships between women.

The importance and significance of relationships is highlighted in Vassanji's 'Leaving:'

Mr Velji was a former administrator of our school. He had a large egg-shaped head and a small compact body. With his large forehead and big black spectacles he looked the caricature of the archetypal wise man. He also had the bearing of one. The three of us were settled in his siFng-room chairs staring about us and waiting expectantly when he walked in stiffly, like a toy soldier, to welcome us.

"How are you sister?" he said. "What can I do for you?"

Aloo and I stood up respectively as he sat down.

"We have come to you for advice ...," Mother began.

"Speak, then," he said jovially and sat back, joining his hands behind his head. She began by giving him her history. She told him which family she was born in, which she had married into, how she had raised her kids when our father died. Common relations were discovered between our families...



7.4

SOME KEY RELATIONSHIPS

THE EXTENDED FAMILY

The extended family tends to be influential, both in the real lives of people in East Africa, and in the fiction from the region. The particular case of interfering uncles and aunts is widely

documented. In *The Invisible Weevil*, for instance, it seems that the visit from an uncle is the beginning of the end for Genesis. At the beginning, theirs is a fairy tale romance. Genesis is very happy when Nkwazi is promoted to the position of Deputy Minister. It is after his visiting uncle declares that he has “no wife” that Genesis begins to distrust Nkwazi. The uncle, not familiar with the set up where a wife can have a full time job outside her house, is reacting to the fact that Nkwazi leaves the house in the morning and returns in the evening. The uncle’s words create doubt. Genesis becomes suspicious of innocent situations. In the end he decides to hit back by getting himself a mistress. The primitivism of Genesis’ uncle is to blame for wrecking their marriage, and for the death of Genesis.

In some instances, the distant nature of some of these relationships is hilarious, as in the case of Cousin Sarah in ‘The Winner.’ Below is an extract from ‘The Winner’ in which the nature of the relationship between Pius and Cousin Sarah is revealed:

“I believe my late husband knew you very well, sir,” she said to Yosefu. “He used to be a Muruka chief in Buyaga County. His name was Kivumbi.” “Ah, yes,” Yosefu replied, “I remember Kivumbi very well indeed. We often hunted together. I was sorry to hear of his death. He was a good man.” Cousin Sarah shrugged her shoulders...

Hearing this enabled Pius to define the exact relationship between himself and Cousin Sarah, and even by Kiganda standards, it was virtually nonexistent, for the late Kivumbi had been the stepson of one of Pius’s cousins.

AFRICANS AND THE FORMER COLONISERS

In addition to the normal bonds of kinship and neighbourliness, there is the love-hate relationship between the Africans and their former colonisers; teachers and their students, priests and their parishioners, and between employees and their employers. For instance, it has been said that the single most important influence on the first crop of African students in Kenya was Carey Francis, a Maths teacher at Maseno School and Alliance High School. It is also a fact that most senior government officials in the 1970s and 1980s had been taught by him. It is therefore safe to assume that the character of a European school master in the early novels and short stories would probably be fashioned after Carey Francis. In the same way, every mission had a resident priest. Even long after independence the resident priest continued to be of European origin. Indeed, Wahome Mutahi in his humorous 1990s newspaper column ‘Whispers’ had a prototype priest by the name Father Camdessus. There were doctors too, as in Kariara’s Kiriti:

From: Jonathan Kariara’s “The Coming of Power”

...Dr. Ian Macgregor. This ScoFsh doctor had been at the mission for many years and had a greater reputation as an architect than a doctor. He was happiest when supervising the addition of a new wing to the hospital, or an extension to

the cookery room in the girls' boarding school next door. His high cheek bones pulled the skin of his face tightly away from his large straight nose. His hair was thinning, but he was so large-boned that he gave the impression that he would live to be ninety.

As in the case of Dr Macgregor, a mzungu character in a story where most of the other characters are indigenous Africans is almost always a caricature. Interestingly, the relationship between the one mzungu and the whole village of Africans is almost always the same, irrespective of whether that mzungu is a teacher, a priest, or a doctor. The whole village looks up to him for leadership. This is the reason the villagers at Kiriti send a delegation to discuss the question of electricity with Dr Macgregor.

EMPLOYERS AND EMPLOYEES

The relationship between employers and their employees is also quite common in East African prose fiction. The government is the biggest employer. The civil service holds great attraction for fresh graduates and civil service jobs are prestigious appointments. In 'Transition,' for example, Mzee Amri is looking forward to the day his son completes school and joins the civil service, so that he can upgrade the whole family. Once they get their civil service jobs, however, the characters do not seem to understand that they are in paid employment. Many of them use their offices as bases from which to run their personal businesses. Indeed, Manna Leitao is the exception to the rule, because he uses his own money for his money-lending business. In Petals of Blood, there is an education officer by the name Mzigo. He is the quintessential lowly civil servant, based in the rural areas. Instead of spending his working hours doing the work he is paid to do, he sits in his government office doing personal business. When he occasionally remembers his official duties, it is to patronise, intimidate and generally persecute the likes of Munira, hard-working officers who are trying to make an honest living.

There is a big difference in the employer-employee relationship between the civil service and the private sector. In the private sector, this relationship is characterised by suspicion and animosity. There is generally a surplus of labour. For every job opening, there are millions of applicants, all of them suitably qualified and capable of surpassing the employer's expectations. The employers tend to choose the least qualified and therefore the cheapest candidate. They then proceed to mistreat the employee, remembering to taunt him from time to time with the information that there are a million qualified applicants lining up on the street to step in the minute he quits. Below is an excerpt from Mativo's 'The Second Delivery':

"Do you want this job or not?" enquired his boss with a threatening look.

"I need this job as much as you need your dairy, Mr Mako," said Ndani with a tired voice, but I'm not ..."

"I have five other dairies," interrupted Mr Mako. "I don't need this dairy as much as you need your job. I can do without it and still stay in business." He stopped and wiped out his mouth to clear some foam which had developed during his strenuous lecture.

"As I was saying," continued Ndani, "I'm not late on purpose. I wouldn't want to be, and you know very well that I'm not usually late. In fact sometimes I arrive here before five o'clock..."

"I'm not interested in that," said Mr Mako, "I'm not in a position to hear excuses. And don't begin entertaining silly thoughts about being ill-treated. I would say the same thing to my own son if he proved to be lazy." He walked behind the counter and began pulling out cases of bottles of milk "Now get up and get moving. Whatever happens we have to deliver the milk to our customers. We musn't keep them waiting any longer. Go get the bicycle and check the tyres while I arrange the cases."

Meanwhile Ndani had stood up and walked to where Mr Mako was. Slowly and beggingly he said, "Mr Mako, I came to ask for a day off, today, that is, and to borrow some money from you. You can deduct it from my monthly pay." Mr Mako looked at him with that scornful expression of his, this time in total disbelief.

"What exactly are you talking about?"

"I want to borrow some money from you, and I would also like to take today off. My wife is about to be delivered of a child any time today. I haven't contacted any midwife because I hope to take her to the hospital, if you lend me this money."

"Do you mean to say that this milk will not be delivered to my customers today?"

"It will, Mr Mako, but I must make sure that my wife is delivered of this child. At any rate you can hire somebody on cash basis. Can't you see, I'm in trouble."

Quickly Mr Mako pulled a few more milk-cases, opened one of the drawers, took a piece of paper and a pencil, and after calculating something, counted 150 shillings which he gave to Ndani saying, "All right, I will do exactly what you want me to do; take your money and go."

"Take it and go," insisted Mr Mako. "You asked for it."

"But I meant to borrow it."

"You don't have to, it's your money."

There was another uneasy silence. Then Mr Mako threw the money on top of the counter, after which he said, "You don't imagine I can be cheated so easily, do you? How can I trust a person like you with no single cent in the bank, no proper family background...nothing. Besides, I can't have you back after all the loss you have caused me today. You can go, and if you want you

can appeal for help from your labour union, or whatever it is that is supposed to safeguard your welfare, then we shall see what happens.”

ABSENTEE FATHERS

In addition to the above, there is an important relationship in East Africa which is defined more by its absence than by its existence – the absentee fathers.

In the last lecture we talked about urbanisation and the fact that it has had negative connotations from the beginning. The consequence of this attitude is that men would go to urban centres to seek employment, and the women would stay ‘home.’ In this way, the man’s home remained in the village, where everything is purer and more blessed, while he went into the ‘cruel, evil town’ to provide for his family. Because of the distances involved, the nature of the work, and the cost of travel, these men did not come home regularly. With time they would acquire other interests and stop coming home altogether, as is the case with Martin in Coming to Birth. This plot is repeated in many other stories, and in the real lives of East Africans.

From time to time, the media runs a story about a neglected old man. The storyline is almost always the same. At the height of power and success, a father in his 40s or 50s deserts his family. Sometimes, the father chases his children away from home in anger. The end result is the same. The children are still young and struggling through school. Psychologically, it is at this time that they need their father the most. The mother struggles to raise the children on her own. By a strange twist of fate, all the children become successful, respected leaders in the community. But they grow up feeling bitter because their father abandoned them.

Then one day, the old man resurfaces. By this time he is old, grey and tired: totally spent and at death’s door. He wants to capitalise on the bonds of kinship, bonds which he did not cultivate when he had the upper hand. The children see him as a stranger in need of palliative care. If he is lucky, they pay for him to stay in an old people’s home. Otherwise they ignore him and carry on with their lives as if he did not exist. Their feelings are probably similar to those of the character in Dying in the Sun:

God, his father! He had never known what the word father meant, now or any other time. He never understood what brought him here. It was not filial piety. That had gone, since filial piety is only a meaningless response, in the way that a child learns to go to the toilet and sticks to the custom once and for all for sixty years. He had come to see a man he had never known, a man who a hundred times had kicked him out while he was hungry and half naked. This man had caused the death of his mother through unfairly inflicting upon her the corroding sorrow of the spirit. This man’s sole claim on him was fatherhood – and he was not even sure of that. His only real claim on him was that he was a fellow sufferer. We suffer together and therefore we are relatives.



7.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture I have talked about some of the relationships that are common in East African prose fiction. In the next lecture we shall talk about two issues which are commonly associated with urbanisation, but are a feature of life in both rural and urban areas: materialism and immorality.



7.6 ACTIVITY

Read the following excerpt from 'Moneyman,' a short story by Peter Nazareth. Note the key word and phrases used to describe Mr Manna Leitao. Use those key words/phrases to write a character sketch of "Moneyman".

Mr Manna Leitao had joined the civil service at a time when no Goans owned cars. In those days, it was quite normal for him to be seen walking all over the place, holding his umbrella like a walking-stick. But now, decades later, when Goans had passed through the bicycle age and were affluent enough to own cars, it was strange to see him drifting doggedly along the footpaths and bylanes. He seemed to creep along the edge of one's consciousness, until one suddenly wondered, 'Who is this odd-looking fellow?'

Odd-looking indeed he was. He had a large mouldy face. The hair on his head looked like one of those ferns you see at a swamp – pokers sticking out at the edges and disappearing into a disc at the centre. His ears italicized his head, hairs standing out of them like mini-television antennae. His lips looked sensual, lending credence to the story that he was secretly a satyr, although he had never married. The Goans thought that he had remained single because looking after a wife and children would cost too much.

He often boasted that he was the richest man in the little town of Apana. Incredible, for how could a lowly civil servant who never played the stock market get rich? Well, in two ways. The first was the straightforward one of usury. There were always other lowly civil servants in Apana, particularly

Africans, who were dead broke around the third week of the month. The bankers never lent money to those who really needed it, so this was where The Man stepped in. He would lend money for a maximum period of two weeks at about forty per cent interest. Not per annum but per two weeks.

This is why Manna Leitao came to be known as Money Leitao and, finally, Moneyman.

Then there was the second way he made money. He did not spend any.

Late one evening, Mrs Carmen Dias heard a groaning outside her house. She told her husband and son to investigate. They found Moneyman lying in a gutter in their compound, holding his leg in agony. The story went round later that Moneyman was chasing a spry young African miss across the lawns when he fell into the gutter and broke his leg. Yes, he broke his leg, as the Dias discovered eventually. They would have discovered it sooner had they taken him to the Grade A hospital but, despite his pain, he insisted that they take him to Grade B, where the poor were treated free of charge. His leg was put in plaster, and he was put to bed.

The Dias wrote about Moneyman's plight to his only traceable relatives, who lived in a neighbouring country. They arrived post-haste. Moneyman refused to see them. 'They have come here hoping I will die,' he said. 'They only want to get my money. Well, I won't, and they won't. Off with them!' Despite all efforts, the relatives had to give up and return home in disgust.

So Moneyman had to be looked after by the Dias. They felt that he was their responsibility as they had found him on their doorstep, so to speak. Who would look after this stubborn old man if they refused? They even cooked his meals because he said he could not eat African food. Father and son had to take turns cooking the meals because Mrs Dias had already made plans to go to Goa to visit her parents, and Moneyman's leg took a long time to heal. Needless to say, Moneyman did not pay the Dias anything, taking advantage of traditional Goan hospitality. What is more, after he realized that he was assured of regular meals, he started telling father and son what sort of meals to cook!

Moneyman's brush with death must have made him realize what a lonely man a single man is. At any rate, not long after he left the hospital, he gave up his lonely house and moved in with a family, the Fernandes. The Fernandes consisted of mother, father and three sons....

'You bastard,' he yelled at him. 'You have been staying with us, no? Do the few shillings you have lent us make up for the inconvenience? But you have the cheek to write an insulting letter to my mother! I'll teach you!' And he began beating up the old man.

The eldest and the youngest sons pulled the second son back, but not before Moneyman had had his other leg broken. The eldest son had to take him to the Grade B hospital. After all, the car contained Moneyman's petrol.

Moneyman was abandoned at Grade B. He sent word to the Dias, who found this time that they could leave a stubborn old man to his distress without any qualms of conscience. When Moneyman was finally discharged, he did not press charges. He had nothing in writing, while the Fernandes had. Besides, the lawyer would cost too much.

But Manna Leitao has benefitted from his experience; he has learnt his lesson. He does not trust people any more; people are not as dependable as money. He can still be seen walking around Apana, shabbily dressed and with the ubiquitous umbrella; and whenever he passes the thriving Fernandes Press, he mutters to himself and tightens his grip on his umbrella, as though it is a bankroll from which he does not wish to be parted.



7.7 FURTHER READING

Macgoye, Marjorie. Coming to Birth. 1986.



7.8 SELF-TEST QUESTIONS

1. Name at least five kinds of relationships which are common in East African prose fiction. For each, provide an example from the stories or novels discussed in this course.
2. Describe the relationship between Wanja and other characters in Ngugi's Petals of Blood.

LECTURE EIGHT

MATERIALISM AND IMMORALITY



8.1 INTRODUCTION

We have now come to lecture eight in the series East African Prose fiction. In lecture seven I talked about some relationships that are common in East African prose fiction. We saw that in addition to the usual relationships of kinship, there are a few unusual ones which crop up in the prose fiction. In this lecture I shall talk about the relationship between people and material possessions as depicted in East African prose fiction. I shall then talk about the commodification of sex and the question of corruption as presented in fictional works.



8.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Explore the concepts of materialism and immorality as they relate to East African prose fiction.
- Discuss the phrase 'status symbol' and name some status symbols that are common in East African prose fiction.
- Isolate the themes of materialism and immorality in specific prose works of East Africa.
- Discuss the issue of corruption as it is presented in some of the works of fiction.



8.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

The themes of materialism and immorality are connected. To start with, love of material possessions to the exclusion of everything else including the life of self is in fact immoral. Even so, it is very difficult to define the concept of materialism. Materialism is equated with the love of money and material possessions above all else. However, since we all need money to survive and interact with others in society, it is not easy to draw the line between materialism and a normal drive to succeed since the question of how much is enough is subjective. In stories where there is a character who is a confirmed miser, such as “Moneyman,” it is possible to talk of materialism without fear of contradiction. In many others, it is a bit problematic. In practically all the novels and short stories, the question of material possessions will arise. Sometimes characters will revise their value system during the course of the story, in which case perhaps they can be said to be materialistic only in a given context. Furthermore, as cultural values change, so do status symbols. In the older communitarian societies, the number of livestock, wives or children determined a man’s worth and standing in society. Later, as the value of education began to be appreciated, formal education qualifications became a status symbol. Here is a glimpse into the mentality

...during my last holidays before graduation, I was dreaming of a world that would soon be mine. With a degree in Economics and Commerce, any job in most firms was within my grasp. Houses, Cars, shares, land in the settled area... (A Mercedes Funeral)

With time, especially when being a university graduate was no longer synonymous with a well-paying job, even education qualifications lost ground to the actual possessions. Predictably, once the possessions became status symbols, it no longer mattered how they were acquired. This change in value systems is captured in Wahinya’s changing aspirations in “A Mercedes Funeral.”



8.4 MATERIALISM

In contemporary East African society, the genesis of materialism, and the condition that is sometimes referred to as ‘grabiosis,’ can probably be traced to the land question. Land as a measure of wealth is a relatively new concept in Africa since in the older African communities land was a shared communal asset. As the old communitarian societies declined towards the end of the nineteenth century, a more aggressive, individualistic type of society developed. Along with land, the appetite for other possessions was awakened. Indeed, since land is immovable, it was quickly overtaken by portable and more conspicuous assets as a status symbol. Nevertheless, it has continued to feature in prose fiction. In ‘The Coming of Power’, for

example, the villagers are more worried about losing their land than about the actual impact of electricity in their vicinity.

Land

Sometimes it is possible to hear people boasting of the amount of land they own, in a bid to boost their public image. But since people do not walk around with title deeds, this fact is difficult to confirm. The land in question may be a piece of unproductive rock, or acres of ocean that are visible for only a few minutes of low tide. The prestige comes from praise by third parties, which may not always be done in the presence of the land owner. Owning real estate in the urban centres, especially if it is developed and bringing in a monthly rental income, is a notch higher than just owning land. For instance, there is a hint of pride when Steve in 'When the Sun Goes Down' says to his friend Kanja, "You must have heard I bought this building." Steve is talking about a newly painted one-storey building in an urban centre, clearly a possession only of the rich by local standards.

Money

Undeniably, money is the number one status symbol. The more money one seems to have, the more esteemed one is. However, it would be pointless to claim to be the richest man if other people see no proof of it. In the case of "Moneyman," Manna Leita does not spend any of his money unless he is forced to. Even when he is in pain and in need of urgent medical attention, he chooses to go to the Grade B hospital where he will be treated for free. When he lends money to people, he always expects to get it back with interest. Those who spend lavishly are held in greater esteem, even when the money is borrowed. When it comes to spending money, there is a very fine line between being generous and being obscene. In the case of 'A Mercedes Funeral,' that line was crossed:

But somehow, no applause came; not even a murmur of approval. Something had gone wrong, and we all felt it. It was like an elaborate joke that had suddenly misfired. Or as if we had all been witnesses to an indecent act in a public place. The people stood and started moving away as if they did not want to be identified with the indecency....

Wahinya was buried by relatives and friends in a simple coffin which, of course, had been blessed by Rev. Solomon.

Cars

The motor car, being conspicuous, portable and transferable, has become a prominent status symbol. The narrator in The Hyena's Wedding gives us the reason "It was the only vehicle around in Kayumba sector, so I was always noticed whenever I set out on a mission. The vehicle became my second identity." There is also an interesting episode in To Become a Man, where an old poor man suddenly becomes a star just by sitting inside the car of a missionary. In the 1980s, motorised transport was still a novelty in East Africa. Public transport, especially in the

rural areas, was in the form of an old bus like the one that takes Bena to town in 'The Road to Mara':

...She heard it before it came into sight, groaning as if in great pain as it negotiated the gradient near the village. Presently it rounded the bend, an old green bus, smoking and shuddering, boxes and bicycles piled precariously on the roof-rack.

For the majority of the East African population, even having enough money to ride in this old bus was a privilege. Owning a car was therefore nothing but a dream. The mystery was deepened by the fact that very few people knew how the engine worked. When car ownership became possible, therefore, the prestige of owning a car was that much higher. Very few people had the right combination of what it took to own and drive a car: money, guts and skill. The car is almost a fetish. If someone owns a car, it is one of the first things that will be mentioned about him. This is captured in many of the novels and short stories we have studied.

Clothing and household goods

The first thing we see when we meet someone is the outward appearance. The description of a character in fictional writing will usually include items of clothing. Our first impression of someone depends on dress code and sense of fashion. This has had two interesting consequences in East Africa, which are reflected in the literature. The first is the development of a market for second-hand clothes. The logic is that a designer-label outfit is a designerlabel outfit, irrespective of whether it is second-hand or brand new. The other development is the existence of a flourishing clothes industry: a personal designer for each one.

For those stories that have an urban setting, residential quarters, furnishings, running a business, funerals and many other facets of daily living are sometimes commodified and used as status symbols. In each and every city, there are certain 'up-market' areas with which people want to be identified. Then there are the low-income or slum areas. For writers of fiction, giving the name of a character's residence is therefore part of characterisation. In The Hyena's Wedding, for example, the Member of Parliament (MP) for Nyamata resides in "Kimihurura – a residential area for important men in the country." For the rural areas, it is the size of the house, and the materials used to construct it, which define the status of the character. The building materials include the following:

- Mud walls and grass thatch
- Mud walls and iron sheets
- Brick walls and iron sheets
- Stone walls and iron sheets

- Stone walls and brick tiles



8.4.1 IMMORALITY

Immorality in fictional works has traditionally been presented as an off-shoot of materialism. The general plot is that girls who do not find husbands, or do not want the responsibilities of being wives, will get involved with older men who already have families, for the sole purpose of benefitting from the man's money. In the later writing, however, many more instances of immorality are included. For instance, in Coming to Birth, there is no doubt that Martin engages in extra-marital affairs after he has physically and psychologically abused his wife and then sent her off 'home' to the rural areas. In Petals of Blood, there are many interesting episodes that point at immorality and a decadent lifestyle. In particular, there is Wanjia's traumatic experience with Kimeria. In her case, the traditional storyline has been reversed.

She is an innocent school girl who believes everything Kimeria tells her. He is a cheat and a hypocrite. The reader also gets the impression that Wanjia is not the only innocent school girl that Kimeria has seduced.

In prose fiction of the twenty-first century, the question of immorality takes on criminal overtones as we read Waithaka's The Unbroken Spirit and Bw'Atebe's Verdict of Death. The two novels present a decadent society where immorality is but an insignificant part of a wider web of social ills.



8.4.2 CORRUPTION

Much like immorality, corruption is a feature of East African prose fiction which is presented as an off-shoot of materialism. When people find that it is taking them much longer to acquire the material evidence of success than they had anticipated, they bend rules in an effort to speed things up. Tragically, the practice is rampant in the civil service and other public offices, among people who, due to the nature of their jobs, should be of unquestionable integrity.

There are certainly some honest individuals even in the civil service rungs, but these are few and far between. As is to be expected, a fictional character who is a policeman will probably be

corrupt, for the same reasons that when we encounter a policeman in real life, he will demand and accept a bribe. For the same reasons, in much of the later fictional writing, wherever politicians or other members of the ruling elite are presented in fiction, one of their defining characteristics is the misuse of power, resources and public offices for personal aggrandisement.



8.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture I have talked about the social evils of materialism, immorality and corruption. We have seen the genesis of materialism and its manifestations in East African prose fiction. We have noted that immorality and corruption are off-shoots of materialism. We have also noted that immorality is sometimes glossed over because sex matters are taboo. In the next lecture I shall talk about another subject which is also taboo in the domestic sphere: violence.



8.6 ACTIVITY

Read the extracts below and make a list of those items which you think are 'status symbols'. Next to each item on your list, write down the words and phrases (adjectives) which are used to describe that item.

from To Become a Man:

His son's promises had once been backed and strengthened by a Reverend Walker (whom the Maasai simply called 'Waka'). Waka had established a mission station at a place called Leshota and had mastered the Maasai language so quickly that the elders started wondering whether he did not descend from the brown Iltorrobo who were related to the Maasai. He had once come on a holiday visiting school boys at their homes in a 'get to know your sheep' programme, and had spoken with Kerea ole Merresho.

'lata enkayoni te sukuul?'

'Yes,' the old man said, 'I have a son in school.'

'Keji ngae?'

'He is called Leshao,' the old man had answered.

'Sidai oleng.'

'Ashe.' The old man thanked the Reverend for his compliment. He was so pleased that his usual wrinkled face was as smooth as an egg. He was not so much interested in the conversation as he was proud to be seen talking to the white man. In fact, he wished there were more people in the village than there were at that moment. He wished his wives were still there to see his superiority. But the white man was nobody's fool. He knew immediately what the old man wanted, so he asked him, 'Can you come and we talk in my car?'

'Yes,' the old man answered, his quivering lips filled with joy. That did the trick. Women came running, carrying their babies while the bigger children ran close behind. The jingling of the bangles and copper wire on the women's legs and the rattling of their heavy loincloths filled the air. As they knew that Waka was never after kodi, they assumed he liked the old man, especially when they saw them laughing together. They too laughed and the children praised the old man.

The following words, phrases and sentences, are taken from Ngugi wa Thiong'o's 'A Mercedes Funeral':

"...Worsted woollen suits, starched white shirts and ties to match ... now that's what I call proper dressing..."

"... Shall we ever capture that genuine respect for death in an age where money is more important than life?" Today what is left? A showbiz. Status..."

"...it's good our people are rising...like the owner of these buses...the other day he was a matatu driver...now see him, the owner of ten buses. In one day he can count over 100,000 passengers. Not bad, he?...I will buy a Peugeot...start a matatu...I tell you no other business can beat transport business for quick money except buying and renting houses. .. "

Item No. 1: Money. It was decided that the amount each would give would be disclosed and announced...

Item No. 2: Transport. J. J. J. Had offered what he described as his wife's shopping basket, a brand new, light green Cortina GT...

Item No. 3: The pit.

Item No. 4: The coffin and the cross.

- *From the student, a simple wooden coffin and wooden cross*
- *From the farmer, a wooden affair on which is painted a picture of a green cow with udders and tits ripe with milk.*
- *From the businessman, an elaborate affair built in the shape of a Hilton Hotel complete with storeys and glass windows.*
- *From the MP, an immaculate model of a Black Mercedes-Benz 660S complete with doors and glass and maroon curtains and blinds.*

....

About the elections, the outcome I mean, there is little to tell. You know that J. J. J. is still in Parliament. There were the usual rumours of rigging, etc., etc. The student got a hundred votes and returned to school. I believe he graduated, a degree in Commerce, and like me he joined a bank. He got a loan, bought houses from non-citizen Indians and he is now a very important landlord in the city. A European-owned estate agency take care of the houses.

The businessman was ruined. He had dug too deep a pit into the loan money. His shop and a three-acre plot were sold in an auction. J. J. J. bought it and sold it immediately afterwards for a profit. The farmer-chief was also ruined. He had sold his grade cows – all Friesians – in expectation of plenty as an M.P. J. J. J. saw to it that he never got back his old job as a Location Chief.

You go to Makueni Chang'aa Bar where Wahinya used to drink in his last days and you'll find the ruined two, now best friends, waiting for anybody who might buy them a can or two of KMK – Kill-Me-Quick. It costs fifty only, they'll tell you.

J. J. J. still rides in a Mercedes-Benz – this time 660S, just like mine – and looks at me with, well, suspicion! Four years from now ... you never know.



8.7 FURTHER READING

Imenda, Sitwala. Unmarried Wife. 1998.

Waithaka, Wanjiru. The Unbroken Spirit. 2005.



8.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

What is the relationship between materialism, immorality and corruption as depicted in East African prose fiction?

LECTURE NINE

VIOLENCE



9.1 INTRODUCTION

This is lecture ten of ALT 200. In the last lecture I talked about materialism, immorality and corruption in East African prose fiction. In this lecture I'm going to talk about another common theme in East African prose fiction, violence. Violence refers to behaviour which is intended to hurt. It is not possible for someone to hurt you if you are not there. There are of course different

types of violence, and different locations where violence happens. In this lecture we shall discuss the theme of violence as it is dealt with in East African prose fiction.



9.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Know and understand some forms of violence which are dealt with in East African prose fiction.
- Pick out, as you read a given text, those words or phrases which imply violence.
- Understand some of the circumstances and patterns which predispose you to violence and how to avoid or overcome them.



9.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

Violence can take many forms. It can be physical, verbal or psychological. Oftentimes it is a combination of two or more of the above forms. There is a great deal of violence in East Africa. In Nairobi, the capital city of Kenya, even the simple act of walking on the street can engender violence.

It is no wonder, then, that many East African fictional works touch on the theme of violence. In Eric Sikujua's story 'Ivory Bangles,' the violence is institutionalised and enforced. The way the story unfolds can make us believe that when man has failed to enforce it, nature takes over.



9.4 DOMESTIC VIOLENCE

This is the most common form of violence in East African prose fiction. Most of the time, it is disguised as necessary and sanctioned by the society. In Sikujua's 'Ivory Bangles,' the conflict is

actually the fact that the old man does not beat his wife. He has not beaten her since she was a bride. He has not married any other wives to give her competition and make her unhappy. She is now a grandmother. The spirits are not happy. For this breach of tradition, a heavy price is exacted by the spirits.

From Eric Sikujua's 'Ivory Bangles'

The words of the seer were alarming. He had a deep-seated suspicion of the seer, but he was a tribal seer, a priest of the people, and he had to go to him for consultations after he noticed the blood specks on the liver of a goat he had slaughtered. The seer's pebbles said someone was going to die. The pebbles said a wife was going to die. The pebbles said the spirits were jealous of a happy wife, a woman unmolested by her husband until old age, until she was called 'Grandmother'.

He immediately knew it was his wife. 'What can I do to avert this?'

The pebbles said he had to give her a thorough beating. The pebbles said he had to send her to her parents after the beating.

'They can be appeased in another manner. I will give any number of goats.'

'The pebbles said he had to give his wife a thorough beating. The pebbles said he had to send her to her parents after the beating.'

In 'Transition,' the man uses his wife as a punching bag. She, for her part, takes the punches in submissive silence. The tone of the narrative is that this is the normal state of affairs. One of the issues highlighted in Coming to Birth is the question of verbal and physical abuse of the wife by her husband, on which society turns a blind eye and a deaf ear. Although there is no time that violence is justified, in the fictional works the trigger for the violence is a trivial occurrence. In the case of Taabu, all she does is state the obvious, a truth which puts her husband to shame. When Amri beats her, it is not so much because of what she has said as because of his own feelings of inadequacy.

Another aspect of domestic violence is child abuse. This abuse may be verbal, physical or psychological. In Peter Palangyo's Dying in the Sun, the character feels abused long after leaving home. Furthermore, even the departure from home is not intentional. The fact that he blames his father for his mother's death is another form of abuse. In addition to direct forms of violence, there are many fictional examples of homes where children are mistreated and oppressed. Leshao in Ole Kulet's To Become a Man is sent begging by his father during the school holidays. While begging he is subjected to psychological torture by the neighbours.



9.4.1 CRIME AND VIOLENCE

Violence is sometimes related to criminal activities. Incidents of robbery, muggings and carjackings are almost always accompanied by some form of violence. In Grace Ogot's 'Pay Day,' the whole episode is one of violence, because it describes the activities of a gang that breaks into someone's house at month end to steal that month's salary.

From Grace Ogot's 'Pay Day':

It was a thunderous noise, sharp and deafening, though it did not last. The shattered old mahogany door crumbled into a heap and the deadly rock that had caused the damage rolled on dangerously towards the other wall, crushing whatever stood in its way. The voice of a girl, a very young girl, screamed out in terror, and the clear childish sounds tore the silent night. It suddenly cut off, without a whimper or a sob. The rock had stopped rolling too. Its assignment was now done.

....

There was a rustle around the door. Awino stared in horror as two masked figures entered the one-roomed square hut. She screamed, but no sound came out of her parted lips. Then she saw another group of masked men enter the room, and the tips of sharp pangas gleamed in the dim light. Suddenly powerful torches were shone on Awino's eyes, blinding her.

'Give us the money!' a man's voice demanded. 'Give us the money at once!' and he slapped Awino so hard high on the right cheek that for a moment she had a complete black-out.

In The Verdict of Death, there is a lot of violence. The setting for most of the story is of course a maximum prison that is home to hard-core criminals. What is significant about the violence is that it is not logical and it does not serve any useful purpose. The inmates seem to fight for the sake of fighting. This compulsive need for violence has been demonstrated in numerous novels and short stories. In Meja Mwangi's 'An incident in the park,' the violence erupts within an instant, and dies down just as quickly, having done a great deal of damage in just a few minutes.

From Meja Mwangi's 'Incident in the Park':

'I have ten shillings,' he said desperately. 'That's the truth. I swear by my mother's ... you got to let me go.'

The one with the heavy fruit baskets hesitated, but the other marched the old man right ahead.

'Take one,' the seller cried. 'One basket and ten shillings ... you got to let me go. I promise I won't ever repeat the offence. Believe me, I will go straight home until I can afford a licence. Take both baskets, take everything. I have to go home.'

They said nothing.

The fruit seller cursed them and their wives and children. Then swearing loudly he leaped and broke away leaving the surprised constable hanging on to a large piece of his torn coat. His surprise lasted a few short seconds. The constable shot after the fleeing man across the park shouting for help from passers-by. The one with the baskets took two quick steps, found it impossible to run with the baskets and followed slowly. He stopped to pick up his flying mates fallen hat.

The fleeing hawker put a couple of hundred yards between himself and his pursuers. He was certain he could find sanctuary in the crowded city. As he slowed to cross the highway a man nabbed him, alerted by the constables' shouts. He hit out, breaking free once more. Another man lunged for him. Again he lashed out, savagely desperate, and tried to run. He stumbled, falling into the ditch by the side of the highway. People came by. More stones. He cried out, pleaded for mercy. In their thirst for blood no one listened. By the time the constable ran up, the fruit peddler lay like a broken and twisted rag doll at the bottom of the ditch. A chunk of rock, as large as the one the disgusted loafer had hurled at the fish, had drawn thick red blood over the sparsely bearded face.

The constable looked furtively around for someone to blame. No one looked guilty enough. The word 'thief' hovered over the assembled crowd, and, just as it started to permeate through them, the constables conveniently withdrew across the highway into the city. The party hung aimlessly around until a passing police car drew up and demanded to know what was the matter. The inspector cut a path through the spectators, hopped into the ditch and went down on his haunches. He felt the victims wrist, shook his head. He felt the neck. Again he shook his head.

'Dead,' he said, rising to face the spectators. That was his verdict.

Those nearest him lowered their eyes, an automatic defence mechanism against being called upon to give witness. Some drew back and hurried back to their offices. Under the pressure from the police officer's forceful presence, the word 'thief' oozed out again from the back and spread like silent poisonous gas to the front, so quiet it was impossible to tell from which mouth the condemnation issued forth. Here lay a desperate thief, a Fred in the unmistakable uniform of his trade – dirty torn clothes and a mean hungry face.

Now it was the police officer's turn to feel uneasy and uncertain. A thief was a thief. Somewhere in the crowded streets and the twisted garbage-strewn back alleys there was an unwritten law that clearly set down the fate of

apprehended thieves. Now there remained only one thing: to establish the man's identity.



9.5 SUMMARY

We have now come to the end of lecture nine. In this lecture I have talked about the theme of violence as it is presented in East African prose fiction. This lecture has reminded us of the different ways in which violence manifests itself, both in private and in public. In our next lecture, I will talk more specifically about institutionalised differences that lead to open conflict.



9.6 ACTIVITY

Read the excerpt below. List the different types of violence that are mentioned in the story. Against each type of violence on your list, add the name of the perpetrator and that of the victim.

From Peter John Bosco's 'Transition':

'You never draw water. So you don't know what it is like to slip and fall down that steep slope with a debe on your head. You can't see the suffering of the children who have to get up at dawn each morning to go to school and come back late in the evening. You don't see how dangerous it is for them crossing that river, or what they lose when the river is in flood and they can't go to school for a whole week.'

She saw the disbelief in his eyes. But she would not stop yet.

'What sort of man do you think you are? How much money do you get from scratching the bare slopes of the hill for your tobacco crop? Look at what we are wearing: mere rags. The children don't even have uniforms. Look at your friends in Umoja. Look at their healthy children. Look at what their wives wear. You yourself are still wearing magwanda when everybody else is wearing trousers. Don't you feel ashamed going among your fellow men?'

'Shut up, woman!' Amri hissed. But Taabu wouldn't shut up just like that.

'For how long do you want to keep us down? What makes you stick to the barren desert? You are poor. Your hut is roFng away and falling. All of us are suffering, but you would stick to the place like a tick ...'

'I said you shut that gaping mouth, woman! I brought you here with my money. I am keeping you here, and I could send you away anytime I wished to. Are you now telling me where to build a new hut, or what to do with my house?'

'I didn't tell you that,' she retorted. 'I said that we are suffering here for nothing and that I am not going to suffer anymore.'

'Listen, woman. I have told you several times already: we are not going to join those fools of yours in Umoja. I am the man here, and a woman is not going to change my word!'

Taabu had now tasted the bitter-sweet liquor of daring and courage; she would not budge.

'Say what you wish, but I have also told you that I am not going to die for somebody else's lack of sense!'

'What!'

Amri's eyes were blazing. He was on his feet and his long whiskers heaved up and down at her. He remembered Nguvumali, the chairman of Umoja Ujamaa village, and the incident of twenty years ago. The memory stabbed at him like a sharp knife and he once again re-lived the very feelings he had experienced that day. Again the shock of discovery pricked into his flesh like a thousand pin-pointed thorns. Again he felt the opium of rage and humiliation go to his head and intoxicate his brains to madness. He trembled with emotion and struck his wife hard on the mouth. He hit her on one cheek and again on the other. He rained blows on her and forgot that he was beating her. Taabu didn't emit a single sound. She jus collapsed under her husband's blows. He drummed on her sides and lashed at her backside.



9.7 FURTHER READING

Bw'Atebe, Onduku. The Verdict of Death. 2005.



9.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

Describe the three main characters in Peter John Bosco's 'Transition.'

LECTURE TEN

DIFFERENCES AND HOSTILITIES



10.1 INTRODUCTION

We have now come to lecture ten in this series. In the last lecture I talked about the incidence of violence. We saw that violence can and does take many different forms. It can be physical, verbal or psychological. We also saw that violence is not restricted to certain locations such as bars and the streets at night. It can and does happen in homes and among family members. In this lecture we shall discuss physical violence which erupts in the public domain: hostilities between families, communities and states.



10.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Identify the differences which lead to open hostilities in East African prose fiction.
- Differentiate between the different wars that have happened in East Africa in the twentieth century.
- Discuss, on the basis of how each is treated in prose fiction, the wars that have taken place in East Africa.



10.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

Differences and the resultant hostilities have been a part of East African prose fiction since the colonial era. The earliest writing by indigenous Africans carries hints of war: a time when they will drive the colonist away and reclaim their land. In East African prose fiction there are many references to conflicts such as the Mau Mau movement in Kenya or the Maji Maji rebellion in Tanzania. After the East African states gained political independence, however, the reality of war did not come to an end. Some of the countries have been through civil wars. In Uganda, a coup d'état resulted in a military regime for some time, which was later toppled with assistance from Tanzania. Sometimes there is tension between two of the states. These realities are captured in prose fiction.

Hostilities in Burundi and Rwanda eventually escalated into genocide, which I shall talk about in the next lecture. In Uganda hostilities flared into military coups and civil war. At one time or another, the president of Uganda has come close to declaring war on Kenya or on Tanzania. These last two remained relatively stable and peaceful, until Kenya's post-election violence in 2007 and 2008.

The reasons for hostilities in East Africa are many and varied, ranging from economic to social. By far, the single most important factor is the question of ethnicity. Each of the East African countries has within its borders people whose languages and cultures are different. These different groups of people may have united as Africans to oust the colonist. But once the

coloniser was ousted, the differences between the various groups led to hostilities. Sometimes there are hostilities within the same community due to other factors. For instance, in Kariara's 'The Coming of Power', there are differences within the same community even before the coloniser has left.



10.4 THE COMING OF POWER

Jonathan Kariara's short story 'The Coming of Power' is highly symbolic. On the surface it describes the activities of labourers setting up infrastructure for the supply of electricity at the request of the local head of a church mission. At the same time, it describes the subtle ways the Africans used to prepare for the offensive against the coloniser. The labourers perform the duties they are paid to perform. But they do more than this. They recruit young boys for a future offensive, and scout the territory for future use as hiding places. The ending of the story is purposely ambiguous:

By the time electricity was installed at the mission, a hush had fallen on the land. The boys watched the workmen slyly, as they put up a stepdown transformer before connecting the power to the mission. They and the men shared too many secrets to have any need to communicate. They waited for the first blow.

In this paragraph the word 'blow' cannot make sense to the reader who is not conversant enough with East African history to know that the Africans are about to start their offensive against the colonist. Since the story is about electricity, we expect to see a word like 'light'. Under the circumstances, however, light is the farthest thing on the minds of the Africans. In any case, the electricity is not even for them, it is for the mission which is run by the colonist.

The very last paragraph is even more fascinating:

When it came, huge square searchlights at the top of the high poles were erected all round the mission, from which vantage points they poured swathes of blinding light on the surrounding villages.

In this paragraph the pronoun 'it' refers both to the electricity and the offensive. In the absence of an offensive the searchlights would not have been necessary. On the other hand, in the absence of electricity, they would not have been possible.



10.4.1 REMEMBER ATITA

Batanda's story 'Remember Atita' is a record of life in the war torn Gulu province of Uganda. By some strange twist of fate, the death of her parents when she is young saves the protagonist in the story the agony of living in the war zone. Her aunt takes her to the city as a housegirl. Years later she returns to Gulu. She describes the events and surroundings in minute detail, like a stranger. At the same time, she suffers from guilt because she has not been there to experience with her friends the fear, the hardships. She seems to believe that if she had been there, none of them would have died.

I am kept awake by the thought that tonight could be the last time I breathe. Okema tosses and lets out a wail. He is haunted by a recurrent dream each night has told me. Now I know that he dreams about the rebels attacking his home and pulling him out of his mother's grip. And as he is tied and led away, he is followed by his mother's haunting wail as she sees the last of her children being taken...

A little later, in the incoherent words of a fortunate survivor, we have a description of what happens to those who are taken:

They were taken the same day...The men came to the village and rounded them. They tied them with ropes. They carried the things they had stolen and followed them. They were exhausted from the long walk. It was dark... The moon had hidden her face from them. She couldn't make out the faces. We walked at a slow pace. Some of the armed men shouted hiFng them with gun butts and sticks. Someone fell and brought a few down with her. The others quickly got to their feet she stayed on the ground. She turned her face. OYELLA. Our Oyella. One of the armed men shouted at her to get up. She didn't move instead curled herself up. He shouted again and still she ignored him. Her eyes glistened; terror flashed through then was quickly replaced by nothingness. She stilled like she has seen death ahead of her and didn't care what happened after this.

'Do you want to rest?' The man asked.

She nodded with the little strength left.

'Your wish is granted,' he snorted as he fired between her eyes.

This story describes a specific event. However, tensions and hostilities last for long periods of time. From the scant details given, therefore, we must extrapolate the humiliation, the hardship and the fear that make up the ambience of a war zone through the long weeks,

months and years, depending on how long the war lasts. In the case of northern Uganda, the situation is still unstable in 2011.



10.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture I have talked about some of the stories that deal with hostilities which escalate into a full-blown war. We have seen that tensions exist long before the war breaks out. We have also seen that the details provided in the few available fictional works can only describe certain



10.6 ACTIVITY

Read the following excerpt from Moses Isegawa's 'The War of the Ears.' Using this excerpt and your general knowledge of the situation in northern Uganda, answer the following questions:

Who raids the villages?
aspects of war. Either way, it is an unpleasant occurrence that must be avoided at all times.

-
- How come they don't raid towns?
- Why do they take only the children?
- What do they do with the children they take from the villages?

Two kilometres from Beeda's house three boys squatted in a banana plantation and watched a fourth boy cut up a big jackfruit. The leader was given a slab larger than the rest and he attacked it immediately. It was after nightfall, but this was their first meal of the day and it felt wonderful to be feasting on a jackfruit. They munched loudly and threw the seeds at their feet. Irritated, the leader raised his sticky hand and slapped one of the boys on the back.

"Lieutenant, you are a pig. The whole village can hear you chew!"

"I am sorry, Major," the boy whispered. The others took heed and the noise died down.

Major Azizima like to be addressed by his rank. It made him feel older than his fourteen years. His boss, Colonel Kalo, was only three years older yet his face looked like old leather. Major Azizima envied his menacing look, for he disliked his own choirboy face, which had endured despite the hardship in the bush.

Today, they had walked thirty kilometres from their base, hiding in the forest and in tall grass. They were on a mission to spread God's glory and that of God's Victorious Brigades. Major Azizima liked to be sent on missions. He dreamed of becoming a general, which would make him a member of the high command. Fighters who volunteered stood a better chance of advancement, and nobody volunteered as much as he did.

Life at the base was an ordeal. Sex was forbidden, except for the four middle-aged generals who made up the High Command. Colonel Kalo made sure that anybody who broke this rule got one hundred strokes of the hippohide whip. He punished rape with amputation of the left hand, and desertion and theft with death. He planted spies everywhere, against whose word there was no appeal. In the mornings he put the fighters through military drills; in the afternoons, he made them recite the ten commandments and chant the Generalissimo's vitriol against the Ugandan government for hours on end.

Major Azizima usually came away from such exertions with a headache.

The only time the fighters relaxed was when Colonel Kalo was away, which was rare. The only time everybody was happy was on the Generalissimo's birthday and on Sudan's National Day, when Colonel Kalo allowed them to steal two bulls and hijack a truckload of Coca-Cola for a great feast. All the rules and guidelines came from the Generalissimo, who spoke with God and whose name it was forbidden to pronounce.

Major Azizima's mother had died six years ago, killed by other rebels of God's Victorious Brigades. Every day Major Azizima saw the face of Blue Beast, the man who had killed her and forced him to cut off her ears. She took

advantage of the interminable waits between attacks to slip into the cracks in his mind and call his name. "Azizima, who are you? Who are you?" It was an eerie voice, rising from the bowels of the earth, and it made him shudder.

Now read Tom Odhiambo's comment:

In a sense, Kony's rebellion is a consequence of many factors, some actually dating from the colonial era.

Although Kony may be a villain in the eyes of the international community, there is no doubt that his agents have committed atrocities in the name of fighting the Ugandan government.

...

Those who write and speak about Uganda seem to conveniently forget that for as long as Northern Uganda is in a state of war then the rest of Uganda is actually a war-torn country. Those 'spots' of war out there in the bush can easily become the catalyst for another uprising in Uganda, especially now that the NRM government seems hell-bent on maintaining its grip on power. If one added in the mix the 'politics of oil' then Uganda may have on its hands more than just one 'shadowy' figure and a band of bandits to content with.



10.7 FURTHER READING

Allen, Tim and Koen Vlassenroot, eds. The Lord's Resistance Army: Myth and Reality. Zed Books. 2010.



10.8 SELF-TEST QUESTIONS

1. What are some of the lessons we learn from 'The War of the Ears'?

2. After reading through the whole story 'Remember Atita,' enumerate some of the details in the description which confirm that the setting is a ravaged war zone

LECTURE ELEVEN

GENOCIDE



11.1 INTRODUCTION

In Africa today, the word Genocide is synonymous with Burundi and Rwanda. However, these two countries should not be seen as exceptions. What has happened in Burundi and Rwanda can happen at any time in any of the other East African countries, and did in fact start to happen in Kenya at the beginning of 2008. Perhaps logically, the violence we have talked about in lecture nine, and the hostilities mentioned in lecture ten, combine and intensify, culminating in a few days of madness and resulting in the death of thousands, sometimes millions of innocent people. Although fictional works are scanty, we shall discuss the issue of genocide in this lecture.



11.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Name at least two countries in East Africa which are associated with genocide and describe the historical circumstance which made it happen.
- Discuss some of the prose fiction which touches on the subject of genocide.



11.3 A LESSON IN HISTORY

A Brief History of Burundi



Map of Burundi

In both Burundi and Rwanda, the origins of the Tutsi and Hutu as distinct ethnic groups are unclear. The Belgians, and the Germans before them, observed varying height differences among the resident peoples: the Twa were short, the Hutu were of medium height and the Tutsi were the tallest among them. It was also documented that in many cases, those of the tall group also raised cattle and tended to be politically and economically dominant. Those in the middle height group, on the other hand, tended to be poor and more agrarian. This prompted the use of what became known as the “ten-cow” rule. Those individuals who owned more than ten cows were described as “well-born,” equated with Caucasians, and given privileges by the colonists.

The ten-cow rule was not universally applied, however, and the existence of “petits Tutsi” continues to cause much debate in the field. This much is clear, the Belgian census of 1933-34 and subsequent division of “races” exacerbated latent regional and ethnic conflicts.

Burundi’s first multiparty national elections were held on June 27th, 1993, thirty-one years after the country gained its independence from Belgium in 1962. These elections were immediately

preceded by 25 years of Tutsi military regimes beginning with Michel Micombero, who had launched a successful coup in 1966 and replaced the monarchy with a presidential republic.

The last of the coups was in 1987 and installed Tutsi officer Pierre Buyoya. Buyoya attempted to institute a number of reforms to ease state control over media and attempted to facilitate a national dialogue. Instead of helping the problem, these reforms instead served to inflame ethnic tensions as hope grew amongst the Hutu population that the Tutsi monopoly was at an end. Local revolts subsequently took place by Hutu peasants against several Tutsi leaders in northern Burundi; these Hutu militias killed hundreds of Tutsi families in the process. When Buyoya sent in the army to quell the uprising, they in turn killed thousands of Hutu.

On October 21, 1993, Burundi's first democratically elected Hutu president, Melchior Ndadaye, was assassinated by Tutsi extremists. As a result of the murder, violence broke out between the two groups, and an estimated 50,000 to 100,000 people died within a year. A 1996 UN report into Ndadaye's assassination and its aftermath concluded that "acts of genocide against the Tutsi minority were committed in Burundi in October 1993". The report also implicated senior figures in Burundi's Tutsi-dominated army in the assassination. In Burundi, Tutsi civilians have been targets of mass killings and acts of genocide organised by the state and by armed militia groups. They were followed by a long civil war that killed both Hutu and Tutsi.

In 1994, Ndadaye's successor Cyprien Ntaryamira died in the same plane crash with Rwandan President Juvenal Habyarimana. This act marked the beginning of the Rwandan Genocide, while in Burundi, the death of Ntaryamira exacerbated the violence and unrest, although there was no general massacre. Sylvestre Ntibantunganya was installed to a 4-year presidency on April 8, but the security situation in Burundi further declined. The influx of hundreds of thousands of Rwandan refugees and the activities of armed Hutu and Tutsi groups further destabilised the regime.

The civil war continued, despite the efforts of the international community to create a peace process. Ceasefire talks were held in Tanzania in 2000, facilitated by Nelson Mandela. The agreement which established a transitional government, where the presidency and vicepresidency would be rotated every 18 months, sharing power between the Hutus and Tutsis was reached. While the government and three Tutsi groups signed the ceasefire accord, two leading Hutu rebel groups refused to participate, and the fighting continued.

On April 15, 2006, curfew was lifted in Burundi after 13 years.



11.4 RWANDA – UP CLOSE

There are some fictional works dealing with the Rwandan genocide. Many are written by people who are not Rwandese. John Rusimbi's The Hyena's Wedding, is set in Rwanda after the genocide. It dramatises the herculean task of rebuilding the country after the holocaust. The writer is conscious of the realities and acknowledges them in lines such as:

[A novel which] "reveals the untold horrors of the 1994 genocide in Rwanda" (ii).

"negative forces are unchecked or built within the ranks of state leadership" (ii).

[a] "society full of suspicion and mistrust amidst abject poverty" (iv).

[there was an urgent] "need ... to teach the population to live together as a united family" (v).

To gain an insight into the specific atrocities that actually took place, however, journalistic accounts provide more immediate details:

In April 1994, when South Africa was celebrating the end of apartheid with the election of Nelson Mandela and the African National Congress to power, Rwanda, a tiny central African state was awash with the blood of one of its ethnic minorities, the Tutsis. In 100 days, from April to early July 1994, the country's Hutu paramilitary, Interahamwe ('We who strike together'), fattened and armed by its deceased president, Habyarimana, butchered about one million Tutsis. The world chose to look the other way. As the Reuters photojournalist Corinne Dufia put it in her address to the UCLA International Institute on the tenth anniversary of the genocide: '[T]here were thousands of journalists on the African continent during the genocide, but they were almost all in South Africa covering the elections.' The United States, already suffering from Somalia fatigue, refused to name the massacres 'genocide' for fear it would have to intervene once again in accordance with the Geneva Convention. The UN Peacekeeping force present in Rwanda at the time refused to exceed its brief — that of 'keeping peace' — and engage in armed conflict with the genocidal Hutu paramilitary. As the fictional UN General put it in Gil Courtemanche's novel, A Sunday at the Pool in Kigali, 'I would like to protect civilians, but I do not want to risk losing soldiers, even one, without written authorisation. I am not here to save Rwandans. I'm here to respect the Arusha accord.'

When Corinne Dufia implored her editors to allow her to cover the Rwandan massacres as well as the South African elections, they told her that

the public had little appetite for seeing dead bodies in the morning newspaper. They finally allowed her to travel to Rwanda, though, after seeing a particular photograph that caught their interest. The photograph was not of the genocide, but of a massive exodus of refugees from Rwanda into neighbouring Tanzania. 'They finally said, "This looks impressive. You can go."' Dufia and her team chose a route to Rwanda from the southeast, passing through Tanzania and Burundi. Their assignment was to cover the refugee story. Dufia describes the gruesome tableau that lay before them:

There was a river that flowed between Tanzania and Rwanda. There was a large waterfall and there were bodies flowing over it. On the one hand there were refugees going into Tanzania and on the other hand we had these bloated bodies every couple of minutes flowing over this waterfall. It was horrific.

Dufia also gives a graphic description of her experience of visiting churches and schools where many Tutsis sought refuge and were massacred:

You could see the story of the chase in the ways the bodies fell. In one of them I remember seeing a dead mother and her two dead children. You could see she was trying to protect her children and you could see she was huddled over these children — they'd been dead for a number of weeks and you could see the machete marks on her body where the bone was shattered.

The reason why Dufia could still see mounds of hacked bodies was the astonishing decision taken by the Tutsi-led Rwanda Patriotic Front (RPF), which took over the country soon after the genocide, to leave the corpses where they lay, between the church pews, beneath the school desks, in the yard outside. In the words of Michael Ignatieff, who witnessed the grim memorialisation a year later in the company of the then UN Secretary-General Boutros Boutros-Ghali, 'The survivors turned the church compound at Nyarubuye into the Yad Vashem of African genocide'. This is how Ignatieff describes the scene:

Stretched out on the floor are row upon row of dust-coloured skeletons in rags. A dirty light slants across femurs, ankles, hipbones, shoulder joints, teeth, skulls. No flesh remains. There's no smell of putrefaction. The clothing has faded to the colour of ash. Boutros-Ghali shuts his eyes and quietly mutters, 'Everywhere we work, we are struggling against a culture of death.'



11.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture we have discussed the subject of genocide. We have talked about historical issues that caused the Rwandan genocide. We have seen that not much fiction is written as yet on the subject, although some biographies exist and quite a large volume of research work is available. In the next chapter we shall discuss death under the theme of HIV/AIDS, a disease that it is still taboo to talk about in some places.



11.6 ACTIVITY

Read the following excerpt from Malvern's 2000 book A People Betrayed. Using these and other details provided in the media and in the movie 'Hotel Rwanda,' write a summary of the Rwandan genocide:

The people had turned up in small groups, emerging from the eucalyptus trees at the back of the school. There was a girl, aged about six, with a machete wound in her head and a boy with a gaping hole in his shoulder from a bullet. He did not cry. One man had a hand almost severed from a machete blow.

Soon families were camped out in the classrooms, and when these became overcrowded people huddled together in groups on the playing field. Outside the gates of the school the militia brandished their machetes and hand-grenades. They cruised around in jeeps drinking beer, hurling vulgarities and chanting 'pawa, pawa' 'power' for Hutu Power. The notorious Café de Gatenga, where the militia congregated, was nearby.

It was Friday 8 April 1994. Here in Kicukiro, and all over the city, people were fleeing in terror to churches, to schools, to hospitals and to wherever they saw the UN flag. The UN had peacekeepers in Rwanda, the UN Assistance Mission for Rwanda (UNAMIR), and 450 of them came from Belgium. These peacekeepers were spread out in fourteen different locations and the largest group was billeted at this technical school, the Ecole Technique Officielle, run by Salesian Fathers.

There were ninety peacekeepers, part of the southern group, from the 14th company of Flawinne. The school went under the code name 'Beverly Hills'. The commander was Lieutenant Luc Lemaire. He had been in Rwanda for two weeks.

Lemaire welcomed the people, although he wondered how, with so little ammunition, he could protect them. There were explosions nearby and the sound of grenades and shooting. There were roadblocks. Then came the news that ten Belgian peacekeepers had been murdered by Rwandan soldiers. They could all be targets now. Lemaire had tried to reassure the younger members of his contingent.

Lemaire told his commanding officers by radio about the people at the school and he estimated their number at about 2,000. He ordered defensive positions built around the perimeter fence.

The food provided by the priests soon ran out. There was not enough water. There were insufficient medical supplies. Lemaire telephoned the local offices of Médecins Sans Frontières (MSF) and the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC). He was told it was impossible for anyone to get through the roadblocks.

Then Lemaire heard that the Belgian government had decided to pull out its soldiers. It was unbelievable. The Belgians were the backbone of the mission. And what would happen to the people they were protecting? No one had an answer. Lemaire asked a bourgmestre to assemble the crowd and he stood on a chair to explain to the people that while the UN flag flew over the school they were safe, but that would not last. The politicians in Brussels were withdrawing the soldiers. Lemaire advised them to disperse, to slip away under cover of darkness. Several people approached him later and asked if, in the event of a pull-out, he would shoot them first, telling him that a bullet was preferable to being cut to pieces with a machete.

Lemaire spoke with a senior officer in the Rwandan army, Colonel Leonidas Rusatira, who came to the school. Lemaire asked Rusatira if, when the Belgians withdrew, he would make sure that Rwandan soldiers looked after the people. 'I thought this man might be enough of a human being to protect them,' said Lemaire. Rusatira was the director of a military academy and said he had no soldiers at his command. Nevertheless he brought them sacks of rice, although there was only enough for the children.

Lemaire considered escorting everyone to the headquarters of the UN mission, but he wondered if there were enough peacekeepers to look after them even there. To move the people in small groups would require more than ninety soldiers. They risked attack en route.

On Sunday 10 April Lemaire was relieved to see French troops, but they had flown to Rwanda only to evacuate expats. The French soldiers chose from the crowd three French and several Italian nationals. This approach angered Lemaire and he told them that they could at least take all the Europeans. Some 150 people were prepared for departure.

That day Lemaire was ordered to send soldiers to Gitarama, a town some forty miles away, to escort Belgian nationals to Kigali airport. He argued that this would diminish the security of the Rwandans he was protecting. The mission was cancelled, but for other reasons.

Lemaire's final evacuation order came on Monday 11 April and he faltered. He wanted the order confirmed. He contacted headquarters to be sure that his commanders knew the consequences. The log of the battalion records: 'leave 2000 refugees as "Beverly Hills?"' He knew there were people in the crowd at risk.

'I did not want to leave,' he said some years later. 'But I did not think there was any other solution.'

All that was left was to plan the departure. If the people found out what was happening there might be a riot so Lemaire planned for the peacekeepers to leave quietly, as though going out on a mission. By chance a French jeep was passing, and as it drove on to the playing field its soldiers were applauded by the crowd. One by one the UN vehicles left the school grounds. But it was soon obvious what was happening, that the peacekeepers were sneaking away. 'We would not believe what they were doing...just abandoning us when they knew the place was surrounded... There were thousands of unarmed refugees...it seemed unthinkable.'

People tried to hang on to lorries. The Belgian soldiers brandished their weapons, and fired into the air. The French soldiers prevented others from getting too near to the peacekeepers. The French promised the people that they would stay. At 13:45 the last Belgian soldier pulled out of the school. Then the French soldiers left. People started to cry. The bourgmestre, a member of Rwanda's Parti Social Démocrate (PSD), the centre-left opposition party, tried to calm everyone, and told them that they must defend themselves. 'But we had no weapons, not even a stick,' someone said.

Soldiers and militia started firing at the people and throwing grenades into the crowd. Some people recognised as Hutu were put to one side. The vicepresident of the national committee of one of the militia groups, and agricultural engineer, Georges Rutaganda, was in a jogging suit, standing guard at a small entrance located on the side of the athletics field. He was carrying a gun. In the crowd were pro-democracy opposition politicians and human rights activists but the vast majority of the people carried identification cards with the designation Tutsi. There were both young and old people, and some who could barely walk.

Most of the people decided to try to escape to UN headquarters but instead they were herded along the road by militia and soldiers. 'As we walked...the soldiers and militia terrorized us with their grenades and guns...they slapped and beat people up, stealing their money...it was a long walk and the militia were everywhere.'

At one moment the Presidential Guard ordered the people to sit down and cursed and insulted them for being Tutsi, telling them they were going to die.

Then the convoy moved on again. 'As we walked along, the militia were hitting people with machetes. Some of the people who were wounded fell down and were trampled upon.'

They came to a crossroads that led to Nyanza-Rebero and when they reached a gravel pit near the Nyanza primary school they were told once more to sit down. A witness said that Rutaganda was instructing the militia how to proceed; there were militia coming from different directions and they had machetes. 'The Presidential Guard were watching us from a place that was higher than where we were.' Then the soldiers started firing and threw grenades. Some people tried to break through the militia but were struck down with machetes. 'We were so stunned that no one cried out ... it was only afterwards that you heard the voices moaning in agony ... then the Interahamwe [militia] came in and started with the machetes, hammers, knives and spear.' People in pain were told that they would be finished off quickly with a bullet if they paid money. There were children crying over the bodies of their dead parents.

The next morning the militia came back to kill anyone still alive. Survivors of Kicukiro were mostly children who hid under the bodies.

...

In the course of a few terrible months in 1994, 1 million people were killed in Rwanda in circumstances similar to these. It was slaughter on a scale not seen since the Nazi extermination programme against the Jews. The killing rate in Rwanda was five times that achieved by the Nazis.



11.7 FURTHER READING

Human Rights Watch/Fédération Internationale des Ligues des Droits de l'Homme.
Leave none to tell the story, Genocide in Rwanda, 1999.

Anyidoho, Henry Kwami. Guns Over Kigali. Kampala: Fountain Publishers, 1998.



11.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

What are the details of the Rwandan Genocide in terms of date, reasons and casualties?

LECTURE TWELVE

THE HIV/AIDS PANDEMIC



12.1 INTRODUCTION

In the last lecture we discussed genocide. We noted that most of what is written relating to this subject is biographical rather than fiction. It is a very painful subject and those best placed to fictionalise it fell victim. The same can be said of HIV/AIDS. It is a most painful subject and the East African countries are still reeling from its effects. And because of the fatality rates, few of the affected survive to tell the tale. In this lecture we shall talk about the few stories that are available which deal with this theme.



12.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Talk knowledgeably about HIV/AIDS with reference to information gleaned from fictional works.
- Discuss fictional works in which the theme of HIV/AIDS features, and use them to inform, educate and mobilise people to live positively and fight the scourge.
- Become a more sensitive and better carer of those afflicted by HIV/AIDS.



12.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

HIV/AIDS has taken a heavy toll on all the East African countries. Indeed, there was a time not so long ago when it was estimated that in Kenya seven hundred people succumbed to AIDS-related complications on a daily basis. In Uganda the scenario was so grim that they could not even keep up with the numbers. As a theme, HIV/AIDS is dealt with differently by different authors. Generally, however, the key issues revolve around the mysterious nature of the disease, the tenacity of the disease to the extent that “even” the white man has failed to find a cure, the devastating symptoms that are clearly visible to all, the stigma attached to the disease as a result of the first three reasons, and the inevitability of death.



12.4 STIGMA

It is probably a truism to say that all of us are death watchers, and the reason we are death watchers is because we are afraid of death. In the face of death, when the “walking dead” stare us in the face, we are afraid. In the case of AIDS, the death is agonisingly slow and painfully obvious. There is more than ample time for all of us death watchers to comprehend the situation, and to be caught unawares by the dying so that they too understand our revulsion,

our fear, and our aloofness. The loss of dignity associated with end-stage AIDS has led many able-bodied but HIV-positive people to commit suicide, preferring to die while still in the bloom of health rather than wait for the indignity of being a bed-ridden sack of bones, as Genesis is when he is flown home from the city hospital. In any case, not all of us have the resources with which to sustain a comfortable existence without the means of generating a regular income (i.e.: the strength to remain gainfully employed). And not all AIDS sufferers receive the love, support and care that Genesis is fortunate to receive to the very end.



12.5 SUMMARY

In this lecture we have talked about the HIV/Aids pandemic as captured in East African prose fiction. We have seen that HIV/Aids has been a major challenge in East Africa. Indeed, the countries of East Africa have not recovered from the devastation it has caused and fictional representation is still scarce. From what is available, however, we have seen that our cultural values and systems of thought need a major overhaul if we are to survive and thrive.

Fortunately, emerging trends indicate that change is slowly taking place. In our concluding lecture, we shall take a glimpse into the shape of things to come.



12.6 ACTIVITY

Read the following excerpts, then note down some of the physiological manifestations of HIV/Aids:

From Okurut's The Invisible Weevil:

Prologue (pp 1-9)

"Tell us child," started Kaaka in a fearful whisper. "What is it that has eaten up our son? What manner of disease has made his eyes hide in their sockets and his ribs stand out like askaris on a parade ready to be counted? What plague is this that has even power to make the head shrink?" She paused for a few

minutes then painfully asked, "Is t this new disease we hear about, this disease which is still taboo to us? Is it the disease which even the white man has failed to find medicine for?"

Nkwazi looked away as the old ones looked at her with fear, waiting for her to confirm what they already knew. She swallowed. Hard. "It's the disease."

There followed a long silence which was broken by Kaaka.

"But when and how did our son get it?"

"I can't tell when he got it. This plague, they say can stay in a person's body for many years before coming out," she replied tactfully evading telling them how he got it. Genesis had made her swear to keep it a secret. There was another long silence.

Then Kaaka said, "I know what it is. I know what this plague is. It's like a weevil. The weevil eats up a bean. When you look at the bean, you think it is healthy. Then when you open it, you find that the weevil ate it up a long time ago and inside, the bean crumbles to dust. It's nothing but dust inside. I hear that even after death, this weevil keeps on eating the bones of the dead so that when the box of the dead is opened, there is only dust. Oh my son, he has been eaten by this weevil!" And she broke down and sobbed.

Nkwazi knew the bit about the virus eating up the dead was not true but what was the point of explaining it to the old woman at this difficult moment?

.....

Kaaka sighed heavily. "Mwami, do not ask, 'Why did it have to be my son?' Every child is somebody's son, somebody's daughter. A big fear grips us. We're back to the garden of Eden and Adam has fallen again. Adam has fallen again and we all have to pay for his second fall. This disease which we still fear to mention; this leprosy has taken us back to the first book of the Bible and the beginning of the world. This disease has struck badly through the very food of life. The serpent has struck again and has cut off the breasts of mothers. A mother's breast has been rendered useless and mothers now weep together with the barren. Child, if an elder wanted to curse a person who had wronged him, the curse would be: may you see baaya. Do you know what baaya is?"

"No, Kaaka. In fact, I have always wondered what it is," Nkwanzu replied.

"Baaya isn't a frightening animal or thing. It's a happening so terrible that it makes you shake and wonder what we're doing in this world. This is what we're seeing. We're seeing baaya... When you bury your children like we're doing these days instead of your children burying you, that is baaya. We have seen baaya."

...

Pp 201

During this time too, the virus became vicious. It struck right, it struck left. It felled down both the mighty and the wretched and in many areas, it devastated entire families. Every night the fires of vigil could be seen scattered in the front

compounds of various homesteads. The forests were dwindling, AIDS was finishing the trees, taking them to light the fires of vigils. In the deep of the nights, groans of the dying could be heard as parents beat their breasts in agony, crying out to God.

Their children continued to fade and wither away like flowers in the noon-tide heat. The young widows would move and go into other towns and get new husbands. The young widowers would also shift and move to other towns and get new wives. It was a vicious cycle, and the virus hit. How the accursed invisible weevil devoured the children of Adam and Eve as if to mock the new-found peace in the country!

From Kamau wa Goro's 'When the Sun Goes Down':

"... In the shadows ..." he said between bursts of mirth. "In the shadows," he repeated, savouring the words as if they held the key to the complexities of life. "So many of us are used to the shadows that when you dare to stand in the light of day, people behave as if you're the one in the wrong!" he said.

Maureen stole a glance at Kanja. The poor man was fidgeting and sweating. She rose and opened the window. She poured glasses of fruit juice and passed them round. Kanja held the glass cautiously, his fingers shaking like an alcoholic's. "Welcome Kanja. It is great to have you visit," she said. Kanja has not idea how good it is from him to come. When you are suffering from AIDS, one good friend is all you need to make life less suffocating. A person is only a person through other persons," Steve observed.

"You too? Suffering from AIDS?" Kanja breathed the one question he had been afraid to ask. He sounded perplexed.

Steve smiled vaguely. But before he could speak, Maureen weighed in. The story, she seemed to suggest, was hers to tell. "I remember I had gone for a routine prenatal check when the doctor broke the news. When I was diagnosed with AIDS, I had only one prayer. In that moment when the sun seemed to set on my life, I prayed that my unborn child be free of the virus. I prayed that somehow Steve would be free of the virus too. Oh, how intently I prayed. When my son was born and he turned out negative, my night suddenly went ablaze with a thousand stars. But there was one problem. Steve would not take the test. When he finally acquiesced, he was positive. I was devastated. My stars waned..."

Steve knew the signs all too well. The clouds were gathering and soon there would be a storm, a deluge, he knew. He did not like the way she spoke. Her earnestness sounded almost unnatural. And why must she try to sanitise him?

"I have forbidden you to blame yourself for anything!" Steve growled.

"Oh, you don't know how it feels seeing you suffer and knowing that I brought this pestilence on you. But I swear I have been faithful to my husband. I was faithful to you, Steve ..." her voice broke and she burst in tears.

"Listen Maureen, Steve spoke with a tenderness that surprised Kanja. A strange light played in his eyes. "Never cry when the sun goes down for if you do, the tears will not let you see the stars," he pleaded.

...

The boy started to cry. Maureen sat up and took him in her arms. "You know why your friend did not drink the juice?" she asked between her heartwrenching cries.

"Yes, of course I know," Steve replied.

"Why are people so cruel?"

"No, Maureen. Normally, people do not mean to be cruel. Most are just selfish and ignorant. It is normal, I think, to fear the unknown."



12.7 FURTHER READING

Mwangi, Meja. The Last Plague. 2000.



12.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

What do we learn about HIV/Aids from fictional works?

CONCLUSION: INTO THE 21st CENTURY



13.1 INTRODUCTION

We have now come to the last lecture of this course. I have tried to do a quick survey of East African prose fiction. We started off by looking briefly at colonial literature. However, our focus was on writing by indigenous Africans from the East African countries of Burundi, Kenya, Rwanda, Tanzania and Uganda. For historical reasons, East African prose fiction falls into three categories: colonial, post-colonial and late twentieth century (1980-2000). These three broad categories were sub-divided further in order to cover as many themes as possible. By way of summary, this final lecture will be a look into the twenty-first century. I am going to talk about some of the emerging issues that have received attention in creative writing in the twenty-first century.



13.2 LECTURE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Discuss some of the emerging themes in East African prose fiction.
- Understand the relationship between the emerging themes and earlier ones.
- Feel sufficiently motivated to carry on reading East African prose fiction on your own.



13.3 GENERAL COMMENTS

Many of the themes already discussed in this course continue to receive attention from writers in the twenty-first century. There are, however, new and emerging trends which we have not

discussed in previous lectures. These trends include: dysfunctional families, female protagonists, the penal system and happy endings.

In this lecture we shall touch on them only briefly. In the future or in your spare time you can read some of the stories or novels that I shall refer to in passing here.

13.4.1 DYSFUNCTIONAL FAMILIES

On the eve of independence and in the subsequent decades, creative writers in East Africa usually presented the ideal family of father, mother and children. The fathers were providers while the mothers were nurturers. The boys went to school, the bright ones getting the opportunity to study overseas. The girls stayed home and learnt how to become good wives. The one thing that the first crop of creative writers from East Africa were in agreement with the colonist about was that women belong to the domestic space, in the “Victorian” tradition. If girls went to school, it was to study “Homecraft” or “Domestic Science,” like Paulina in Coming to Birth. A home could not be complete without children, as Paulina knows only too well.

East African society has changed a great deal over the years. There are now single parent families, street families and even child-headed families. These realities are reflected in the creative writing. What is notable about the twenty-first century in this respect is that when these family units feature in fictional works, it is not necessarily in a negative light as would have been the case earlier. It is also possible now to see father figures who are irresponsible, and mothers who consciously choose to be single but are nevertheless responsible in executing their parental responsibilities. In other words, the contemporary social realities are represented in fiction without bias. As a matter of fact, Meja Mwangi’s 2007 titles include Mama Dudu, the Insect Woman and Baba Pesa.

13.4.2 FEMALE SUBJECTS

In the twenty-first century, the girl child has almost equal access to opportunities in the education system and in the work place. In the area of creative writing, we have as many female writers as there are male writers. Indeed, in Uganda and Rwanda, the ladies seem to be more active in the field of creative writing. The positive outcome of this is that since writers draw on their experiences to some extent, there are more female protagonists who are not necessarily passive wives or oppressed domestic servants.

In Wanjiru Waithaka’s The Unbroken Spirit, the protagonist is female. Indeed the whole story centres around the sensitive issue of rape, which by definition calls for a female protagonist. Other stories and novels have touched on this issue, but in Waithaka’s novel, a delicate balance between supporting the victims and giving them the courage to report the crime and the strength to live through the aftermath; and the determination to pursue justice and punish the culprits has been achieved.

13.4.3 HAPPY ENDINGS

In contrast to the pessimism of the latter part of the twentieth century, the twenty-first century has seen a marked increase in stories with happy endings. For instance, there are numerous biographies which inspire and motivate readers of all ages to work hard by affirming that success is possible. There are also fictional works with happy endings where the forces of good triumph over the forces of evil. This is especially liberating when the theme is something distasteful like rape, corruption or the penal system. Waithaka's novel referred to above is one such work. Another is Onduku Bw'Atebe's Verdict of Death. Bw'Atebe's novel provides an insight into Kenya's penal system, Kamiti maximum prison to be precise. How the protagonist got into Kamiti in the first place reads like an insider's manual on corruption. As many survivors will attest, being sent to Kamiti is tantamount to a 'verdict of death.' For an innocent man to be sent to Kamiti is a crime against humanity. We feel relieved when he gets out with his life.

Jackee Batanda's short story, 'Remember Atita,' takes the cake for managing to conjure up hope in the midst of despair in dreary circumstances. The setting is Gulu town in the war-torn part of Uganda. The description leaves no doubt that the situation is tense and death lurks at every corner. In spite of the chaos and despair, two souls connect, and look towards the future with hope. It is a phenomenal love story.



13.5 SUMMARY

In this series of lectures, we have surveyed prose writing from East Africa. We have seen that East African prose fiction is much like prose writing from other parts of Africa and the world. We have also discussed some themes which are peculiar to the East African situation for historical reasons.

All examples for this course have been taken from prose writing only. Do keep in mind, however, that the same themes and issues have been raised in the poetry and drama of East Africa as well. There is also quite a bit of life writing and travel literature.

Our discussion of happy endings brings this series of lectures to a close. I hope that you have enjoyed reading East African prose fiction as much as I have enjoyed teaching it, and that you will continue reading it on your own.

As I end this series of lectures, let me remind you that if it seems that many of the themes are negative, it is precisely because the writer plays the role of critic in order to highlight the evils in society. In this way, our vices are highlighted and we are softly nudged to mend our ways.

HAPPY READING!



13.6 ACTIVITY

Read the following excerpt, which is the ending of 'Remember Atita.' Make a note of positive attributes which we would not normally associate with a war situation.

Today Laker smiles brightly when she sees me. She looks different with her hair now cut and clean. The wild look is gone. As I sit beside her, she lifts her hand to caress the scar on my chin. I hold her hand and smile back. Seventeen years have passed since the day we took the photo as smiling children bent towards the camera – the memory of which I carry around like my dreams.

I hold her hand and help her off the bed. She gets up with great difficulty and leans against me. I have to half support her weight. We walk slowly till we reach the door and limp into the compound. We walk and sit under the large mango tree in the middle of the hospital compound. She loves sitting under the shade. Each time I go to see her, we move into the compound.

Laker raises her hand to cover her eyes, shielding them from the sun. She lies with her head on my lap. We ignore the cries of babies and women talking around us. I don't know how long we sit under the tree. We watch the sun disappear and see the shadows get longer as they fall upon the windows. Laker lifts her head and rests it on the trunk of the mango tree. She fixes her eyes on me.

"What's that song we used to sing? She asks.

I smile.

"Min latin do, tedo i dye wor?" I ask and start to hum the tune. I expect her to join in. She closes her eyes and listens to me sing. She nods her head. Then she

turns to me and opens her eyes. I feel her eyes boring through the scar, then at my neck. She laughs lightly.

“Atita, Atita, bangle-necked Atita,” she whispers.

A smile curls round her lips, very slowly, it lights up, and burns brightly like a flame. She remembered!



13.7 FURTHER READING

Chesaina, Ciarunji. The Teaching of African Literature in the 21st Century .
Saarbruecken: Lambert Academic Publishing, 2009.



13.8 SELF-TEST QUESTION

List some emerging themes in East African prose fiction which would have been unthinkable in the 1950s and 1960s.



GLOSSARY

Caricature: A picture, description or imitation of a person in which certain striking characteristics are exaggerated in order to create a comic or grotesque effect.

Commodification: Noun from the verb to commodify. To commodify is to turn something [which by definition is not a commodity] into a mere commodity. A commodity is a raw material or primary agricultural product that can be bought and sold such as copper or coffee.

Despot: a ruler or other person who holds absolute power, typically one who exercises it in a cruel or oppressive way.

Epitome: A person or thing that is a perfect example of a particular quality or type.

Immorality: Noun from the adjective immoral which means not conforming to accepted standards of morality. Morality refers to a set of principles concerning the distinction between right and wrong or good and bad behaviour. Morality also refers to a particular system of values and principles of conduct.

Materialism: A tendency to consider material possessions and physical comfort as more important than spiritual values.

Quintessential: Representing the most perfect example of a quality or class.

Symbiotic: Adjective from symbiosis which refers to interaction between two different organisms living in close physical association, typically to the advantage of both.

Vicious circle (also vicious cycle): A sequence of reciprocal cause and effect in which two or more elements intensify and aggravate each other leading inexorably to a worsening of the situation.



ANSWERS TO SELF-TEST QUESTIONS

Lecture One

1. The five countries that make up the East African Union, in alphabetical order, are:

Year country attained present form (Qn 2)

Burundi	1962
Kenya	1963
Rwanda	1962
Tanzania	1964
Uganda	1962

3 In Rwanda, the following four languages are widely spoken: French, Kinyarwanda, English and Kiswahili.

Lecture Two

1. The setting for each of the following prose works is East Africa between 1930 and 1950: Out of Africa, Something of Value and The flame Trees of Thika.
2. Here are some of the reasons the European immigrants gave each other to convince themselves that they were superior to Africans: The colour of their skin was different, they could read and write, they identified with the ancient civilisations of Athens and Rome.

Lecture Three

1. Novels such as The River Between, and short stories such as 'The Bamboo Hut' were written by the first crop of indigenous Africans to get formal education and learn how to read and write. When they learnt how to read, they discovered that many untrue things had been said about Africa and her people. In writing, the first crop of East African writers set out to correct the negative impression that had been created of Africa. Their stories, therefore, carried positive references to African settings, African traditions and African cultural practices.
2. Common themes in early East African prose fiction during the first phase include, among others:
 - The lives of human beings are part of a bigger reality which is governed by nature
 - Cultural practices have evolved in response to natural phenomena and have functional as well as aesthetic value.
 - Men are the decision makers but their decisions are based on what is of greatest benefit to the family and the community.
 - Although women inhabit the domestic space, they have immense power over events

3. Below are some proverbs taken from early East African prose fiction:

- The windmills of the Gods grind slowly, but they grind exceedingly small. From The River Between.
- Imirimo ibiri yananiye impyisi – a hyena fails to perform two tasks at once. A Rwandan saying. From The Hyena's Wedding.
- Ntabapfira gushira (ending a race [of people] is virtually impossible.) A Rwandan saying. From The Hyena's Wedding.

Lecture Four

1. The term transition is used to refer to different things: the newly independent East African states have to make the transition from being colonised to self-rule; indigenous Africans are making a transition from being illiterate to being literate; the various communities are making a transition from the traditional way of life to a new one which has been influenced by the coloniser; the writers are making a transition from writing nostalgically about the distant past to describing contemporary realities.

2. The three main characters in Bosco's short story are:

- Mzee Amri: An old conservative and dictatorial patriarch
- Taabu: Amri's wife, who bears the heavy burden of her husband's lifestyle
- Tumaini: The first-born son. Amri considers him an investment.

Lecture Five

The journey motif in Ngugi's *Petals of Blood*

The journey forms part two of the novel *Petals of Blood*, and is suspended somewhere between chapter six, which ends part one, and chapter seven, which starts part three. It is given the Title "The Journey" and is framed by Munira's confessional prison notes. In his report Munira repeatedly refers to "the journey." In chapter six he writes, "it was the journey ... it was the exodus across the plains to the Big Big City that started me ...," going on to finish the chapter, and thus to introduce the journey with, "The journey. The exodus towards the kingdom of knowledge" (117-118). In chapter seven, Munira takes up exactly where he leaves off in chapter six, "Yes, Ilmorog was never quite the same after the journey" (190). In the third section of part two, the journey is actually referred to as "epic": "They did not know it, but that night was to be the peak of their epic journey across the plains" (143).

This epic journey across the plains, however, is only part of the story. The physical displacement from Ilmorog to the capital city is symbolic of other journeys. To start with, the journey in *Petals of Blood* is an unmistakable allusion to Christian mythology. Also alluding to The Bible are the titles of the parts of the novel, which taken together form the sentence, "walking towards Bethlehem to be born again ... la lotta continua." The reference to birth and Bethlehem is an allusion to the birth of Jesus. The word again reminds us of the Christian belief that Jesus will come again to deliver his followers. Allusions to the birth of Christ as well

as his return have been made before. Of interest here is W. B. Yeats's poem "The Second Coming," specifically the lines "What rough beast / slouches toward Bethlehem to be born?" It is T. S. Eliot's poem "Journey of the Magi," however, which sets the tone for Ngugi's epic journey: "Were we led all this way / For birth or for death?" In the novel *Petals of Blood*, it is the people of Ilmorog who make the journey, but the end or outcome of that journey is as ambiguous as the feelings of Eliot's Magi.

It is the experiences of the travellers on that journey which constitute a response to the question of "what happened?" According to Christine Pagnouille

The journey is more than an errand for outside help, it is also a quest for some deeper source of life. And for all main characters involved, as well as for the community as a whole, it turns out to be the starting point of changes far deeper than what they had expected.

For Munira, the trek across the plains is the beginning of an inward journey which leads him from the fringes to the centre of action, to the position from which he can now see that man's estate is rotten at heart (118). The journey infuses Karega with enthusiasm to study the past to better understand the present. To Abdulla it is a grim reminder of other journeys, other disappointments. And it takes Wanja back to the city, "mingling her consciousness of the hurt she has suffered in the past with her awareness of the wasteland that surrounds her in the present" (Gikandi 143). The other villagers are also aware of the significance of the journey:

For the journey had presented each with a set of questions for which there were no ready answers; had, because of what they had seen and experienced, thrown up challenges that could never be forgotten not put on one side, for they touched on things deep in their psyche, in their separate conceptions of what it meant to be human, a man, alive and free (197).

Lecture Six

The reasons why people from East Africa would rather be associated with their rural areas than with urban areas include:

- Negative connotations are attached to urban areas by dint of historical association with colonists.
- Accommodation in urban areas is crowded around the amenities. There is less privacy.
- People come from different areas and live in the same town. It is not possible to know one's neighbours. Consequently, people feel less secure.
- Urban areas are associated with higher incidences of crime. It is therefore assumed that urbanites are more pre-disposed to criminal tendencies.

Lecture Seven

1. Below are five relationships which are common in East African prose fiction:

Father-Son	The River Between: Waiyaki and his father
	Transition: Tumaini and his father
White man-Village:	The Coming of Power: Dr. Macgregor at the Kiriti mission
	The old White Witch: Dr. Joseph and the villagers at the hospital
Husband-Wife	Transition: Amri and Taabu
	Coming to Birth: Martin and Paulina
Employer-Employee	The Second Delivery: Ndani and Mr Mako
The ruling elite-The Masses:	Petals of Blood: Nderi wa Riera and the villagers of Ilmorog
	A Mercedes Funeral: J. J. J. And his constituents
Absentee Fathers	Dying in the Sun

2. Of all the characters in Petals of Blood, Wanja probably has the highest number of relationships as below:

	Character(s))	Pertinent details
1	Her parents	They fail in their guardianship when she needs them the most. They kick her out of home when they find out that she is pregnant
2	Kimeria	He seduces her and then rejects her when he finds out that she is pregnant
3	Nyakinyua	The grandmother who stoically accepts whatever challenges come her way. She takes Wanja in and provides her with a home
4	Abdulla	He is the sole entrepreneur in Ilmorog. He gives Wanja the job of bar maid
5	Munira	The headmaster of the only primary school in Ilmorog. He is attracted to Wanja but has inhibitions related to past experiences
6	Karega	A younger version of Munira. He too is attracted to Wanja.

7	Joseph	A destitute boy in Ilmorog. Through him we get to see Wanjia's soft side. She campaigns for him to be allowed to go to school.
---	--------	--

Lecture Eight

The relationship between Materialism, immorality and corruption:

There is a complex symbiotic relationship between materialism, immorality and corruption, culminating in a vicious circle which is almost impossible to break out of.

In the quest to succeed and improve their creature comforts, people sometimes ignore their conscience and engage in activities which are frowned upon by society such as:

- ❑ Young girls from poor families succumb to the lure of money, holidays to exotic destinations and expensive gifts offered by rich older. They agree to sexual relations, knowing full well that these men are married.
- ❑ Sometimes, members of a poor family force the young ladies into these relationships
- People aspiring to get into a certain lucrative business activity for which they have not met the established standards bribe government officials in order to be licensed to practice.
- Land owners bribe council authorities in order to flout city by-laws and construct substandard rental housing units.
- Many times, the government or council officials solicit bribes in order to perform the duties for which they are already drawing a salary from the public coffers.

On the other hand, having succeeded in life, people then have the means with which to engage in these unsavoury activities:

- Rich men lure women with money and an affluent lifestyle
- Both men and women bribe officers for different reasons
- Those already in business use bribes to remain in business without complying with the laid down rules and procedures. The transport industry is particularly notorious. Matatu drivers bribe traffic officers openly in the presence of their passengers for speeding, overloading, and other offences.

Lecture Nine

There are three main characters in Peter John Bosco's 'Transition':

Amri is an old man who lives with his family on a stony hillside. His home is contrasted to the new Umoja Ujamaa village, which he refuses to join on account of old family rivalries. He grows poorer in isolation and watches bitterly as the Ujamaa village prospers.

Taabu is Amri's wife. As such it is her lot to obey her husband's instructions. She bears the full burden of her husband's decision to live in isolation. She carries out all household chores by herself as her husband sits and watches. She fetches water by herself because all other families have moved to the Ujamaa village. She has only rags for clothes. She lives in a dump which is falling apart. When she complains the husband threatens to kick her out.

Tumaini is the couple's first born son. He attends boarding school far from home. His father is looking forward to when he finishes school and gets himself a cushy government job. The father looks on him as an investment.

Lecture Ten

1. Moses Isegawa's 'The War of the Ears' teaches us some fascinating lessons:

- Children as young as fourteen are involved in warfare.
- Many of the fighters have been reduced to empty shells and have not idea why they do the things they do.
- There is really no organised offensive or professional training. Orders are given haphazardly and entrusted to volunteers.
- Under the guise of fighting the government these child soldiers terrorise even harmless civilians and those engaged in gainful production.

2. Details from Batanda's short story 'remember Atita' which indicate that this is a ravaged war-zone include:

- In the distance we hear isolated gunshots.
- ...abducted siblings.
- There's scarcity of food.
- It is impossible to freely walk around.
- ...on other nights when bullets ricochet through the night... spend the nights on the
- Tonight we hear heavy gunshots followed by a loud bang. ¶ I veranda ¶ As he fired between her eyes.

Lecture Eleven

Below are some details pertaining to the Rwandan genocide:

- Dates: 1994, April 6-10
- Estimated Number of casualties: One million

- Trigger: the death of the Rwandan president Habyarimana, in a plane accident. It was assumed that the plane was shot down.
- The majority Hutus killed the minority Tutsi. For a long time the Hutus had felt oppressed by the Tutsi who were in the majority in positions of power.

Lecture Twelve

From fictional accounts, we learn that:

Aids is a wasting disease. All parts of the body are affected including the head. By the time the victim dies, he is nothing but a bag of bones.

The fear of death prevents people from learning more about the disease. Many people are still ignorant about how it is transmitted. This makes them unwittingly vulnerable.

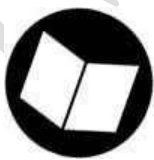
After a great deal of soul searching, people are beginning to take bold steps towards demystifying the scourge in order to contain it.

Lecture Thirteen

Some emerging themes in East African prose fiction would have been unthinkable in the 1950s and 1960s, such as:

Dysfunctional families: the first crop of indigenous African writers were intent on correcting false impressions of Africa made by the European immigrants. They consciously avoided ascribing negative connotations to the African culture or way of life.

Greedy despots: with independence in sight or newly obtained, all indigenous Africans were full of hope for a better brighter future. They had had no experience with indigenous African leaders in the decades preceding independence. Whatever negative qualities they saw in the colonial leaders were ascribed to Europeans as a race, rather than to the individual leaders. The expectation of the indigenous Africans both in real life and in fiction was that African leaders would not exhibit any of those negative qualities.



REFERENCES

1. Gikandi, Simon. Reading the African Novel. Nairobi: Heinemann, 1987.

BY ODHIAMBO DARREN GREGORY.

+254704597085.

2. Grandsaigne, Jean De, ed. African Short Stories. Nairobi: Macmillan Kenya, 1985. Reprinted 1991.
3. Ilieva, Emilia and Waveney Olembo, eds. When the Sun Goes Down an other stories from Africa and Beyond. Nairobi: Longhorn Publishers, 2010.
4. Melvern, Linda R. A People Betrayed: The Role of the West in Rwanda's Genocide. Claremont: New Africa Education Publishing, 2000.
5. Ngugi wa Thiong'o. Homecoming. London: Heinemann, 1972.
6. ---. Petals of Blood. London: Penguin, 1977.
7. ---. Decolonising the Mind. London: James Currey, 1981.
8. Ricard, Alain. The Languages and Literatures of Africa. Cape Town: David Philip Publishers, 2004.